

FOUR DIVERS • ONE BREATH • THE BUSINESS OF THE FILM

Deep Dive

The Producer's Master Book

strategy • money • law • market • execution
one person holds another in the world

VERSION 1.0 • JULY 2026 • ONEMASTERTAKE

for Tomo — producer & director

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I

The Producer's Master Strategy

The playbook: the job, the map, the money, the machinery, the market, execution.

*The whole producing craft, applied to this film. For Tomislav Kovačić, director & producer.
Compiled 14 July 2026.*

Built from nine verified research passes + the project's own documents. Companion files in this folder:

MASTER-PLAN.md (dated operating plan) • RESEARCH-CRAFT.md • RESEARCH-MONEY.md •
RESEARCH-LEGAL-DELIVERY.md • COPRODUCER-SHORTLIST.md • US-FUNDS.md • RELEASES-DRAFT.md •
IDFA-FORUM-ENTRY-DRAFT.md

How to use this: read Part I–II once, tonight. Part III–V are the reference you return to before every money conversation, every contract, every festival decision. Part VI is the calendar you live by.

1 • What a producer actually is

The director asks "what is the film?" The producer asks "how does the film get to exist, get finished, get seen, and not destroy us on the way?" Concretely, the producer owns:

1. **The money** — raising it, planning its arrival (cash flow), spending it against a budget, reporting it.
2. **The paper** — every right the film needs, acquired in writing, filed, provable (chain of title).
3. **The people** — hiring the team, in the right order, on signed deal memos.
4. **The schedule** — shoots, edit, finishing, festival clock, delivery dates; and the discipline when they collide.
5. **The risk** — insurance, legal review, safety, contingency; seeing the trap two moves before it springs.
6. **The relationships** — funders, broadcasters, co-producers, sales agent, festivals. The producer is who they call.
7. **The delivery** — the brutal technical/legal package that converts a finished film into paid money.

The director's currency is trust with the subjects and the truth of the cut. The producer's currency is **credibility with money** — budgets that add up, promises that get kept, paper that exists.

2 • Your dual-hat problem — named honestly

You are currently director + producer + DP + editor-adjacent + app developer + **sole financier**. This is how great first films get started and how they die at rough cut. What predictably fails when one person holds all hats:

- **Financing stalls during shoots** (you can't chase HAVC paperwork from a boat off Lastovo) — and shoots stall during financing.
- **The paper doesn't get done** — releases, deal memos, licenses feel skippable at midnight after a dive day. They are the sale.
- **Nobody negotiates for you** — when you're the director asking the four for life-story rights, you're also the friend; a producer can be the "bad cop" the friendship needs.
- **No one checks your budget's honesty** — solo producers under-budget post by half, always, because the shoot is vivid and the M&E track is not.
- **Burnout** — the only non-renewable resource on this production is you.
- **On-set collapse** — film-school truth (The Independent Film School): try to produce and direct on the same set and you end up producing, with no director on set. Add DP duties in safety-critical freediving conditions and divided attention stops being an inefficiency and becomes a hazard.

One structural advantage you already have: your two camera operators double as post people — that's the **assistant-editor function** (the ADE says the AE should start months *before* the editor, organizing, grouping, syncing transcripts — "proper organization is one of the single most important factors in how quickly an editor can work"). Formalize it: from Lastovo onward they log, transcribe, and string out after every block. That's edit prep, not admin.

The delegation ladder — what you hand off, in order, as money arrives:

1. **Production management / logistics** (first euro of external money): a production manager or line-producer-days for Lastovo/USA — travel, permits, insurance, call sheets, payments. Cheapest hire, biggest hour-return.
2. **Finance & admin > the Croatian co-producer** (before the 10 Sept HAVC rok): HAVC/Eurimages administration, cost reports, audits, contracts. This is what the co-producer attach IS (> COPRODUCER-SHORTLIST.md; Restart first call).
3. **The edit > a real editor** (by assembly, Nov–Dec 2026): the doc editor is the film's second author. You cannot be your own editor on an ensemble feature and keep judgment — you've seen every frame get made.
4. **Sales & festival strategy > sales agent** (from rough cut): their relationships are the product.

What you never delegate: the relationship with the four, the 2023 chapter's handling, final creative word, and signature authority on the company.

3 • Your position on the board (assets & constraints)

Assets: total access + trust of the four (locked by no one else) · 2 of ~7 blocks shot, including an erupting Etna and an unreported world-record blackout with a post-event interview · a provable injustice (negative WADA-lab tests, ITA no-violation, ethics-only ruling, peer-reviewed rebuttal — Škerbić et al. 2025) · a subject inducted into a Vegas hall of fame in the same class as Garry Kasparov (26 Sept, Palms) · zero equity sold · a working production OS (this app). **Constraints:** new company (zero track record — HAVC scores the producer's last 3 films) · €10–25k personal bridge · one person, five jobs · no releases signed yet (fix at Lastovo) · deadline stack: **IDFA Forum 25 July • Lastovo 20 July • HAVC 10 September.**

4 • The eight stages, and where you stand

Stage	What it is	Deep Dive status
1. Development	Story, access, treatment, deck, sizzle; typically 3–12 months	(done) Effectively done (bible, interview architecture, 2 blocks shot). Sizzle = last dev asset, due THIS WEEK
2. Financing	The plan, applications, co-producers, markets; 6–18 months, overlaps everything	(pending) NOW › mid-2027. IDFA Forum › HAVC › partners › Eurimages
3. Pre-production	Per-shoot: permits, insurance, crew, releases, logistics	Rolling per block (Lastovo now; USA in Aug)
4. Production	The shoots	(pending) Jul–Nov 2026: Lastovo (20 Jul–9 Aug) › USA (~3 wks around 26 Sep) › Cyprus variant (27 Sep–10 Oct, the four decide) › Rijeka lab (Nov) › coda
5. Post	Assembly › rough › fine › lock › finishing; 9–14 months for a film like this	Nov 2026 › summer 2027 (see §14)
6. Festival & sales	Premiere strategy, agent, markets	Rough cut spring 2027 › Cannes Docs May › premiere autumn 2027
7. Distribution	The deals: streamer/broadcasters/theatrical/tours	Late 2027 › 2028
8. Delivery & afterlife	The technical/legal package; impact, tours, home release	Q4 2027 › 2028. Budgeted from today, not discovered at the end

5 • The realistic calendar (the one honest version)

- **Jul 2026:** sizzle · IDFA Forum entry (25th) · d.o.o. + Očevnik · releases drafted · Lastovo shoot begins (20th) · lawyer engaged.
- **Aug 2026:** Lastovo (deep 2023 sit, releases signed, family archive, Cyprus decision) · HAVC application built with co-producer · sponsor wave 1 · USA prep (ESTA/insurance/permits/ISHOF/Kasparov release).
- **Sep–Oct 2026:** HAVC in (10th) · USA tour (Vegas 26th) · Cyprus variant · CPH:FORUM submission (early Nov deadline).
- **Nov–Dec 2026:** IDFA + Forum (15–18 Nov) — meet agents (MetFilm first), broadcasters, co-producers · Rijeka lab shoot · rebate application before that block · Whickers submission (~Nov, if budget-cap pre-check clears) · HRT doc editorial meeting · editor hired · **assembly begins.**
- **Q1 2027:** edit · HAVC decision lands (~Dec/Jan) · Eurimages application (first 2027 deadline) once IT/HU partner signed · WEMW/EDP/ZagrebDox Pro markets · coda shoot if not done.
- **Q2 2027:** rough cut › feedback screenings › sales agent formally attached › **Cannes Docs market screening (May)** › fine cut · edit lab if selected.
- **Q3 2027:** picture lock (Jun–Jul) › legal read BEFORE lock › finishing: conform, grade, sound design, mix + **filled M&E**, titles, masters · E&O bound · **world premiere: Telluride (early**

Sep) or TIFF Docs · European premiere held for IDFA Nov 2027.

- **Q4 2027 > Q1 2028:** the sale (weeks-to-months post-premiere is normal) · delivery (budget 2–4 months for it) · Croatian theatrical event release · Banff/Kendal/ocean tours · series version cut for TV/streaming afterlife.

The rule that governs the calendar: the edit is where the film is made — never steal months from post to hit an earlier festival. Sundance 2027 is already correctly dead for this reason; if lock slips, the premiere moves to CPH:DOX/Tribeca 2028, not the mix to half its days.

The honest total: 58% of documentary makers report 1–5 years for the whole project (CMSI/IDA field study); a vérité feature realistically runs ~**3 years from committed development to release** — for us that's mid-2026 > 2028 including the sale and delivery. Budget your life, savings, and the studio's other work for that number, not for the shoot dates. And the ADE's warning stands behind every schedule decision: squeezed edit schedules end up driving total costs *higher*, not lower.

6 · Budget anatomy — what €1.2M actually contains

Memorize the shape, not the lines: **production ~ 30% · everything after the shoot ~ 30% · "invisible" money ~ 25%** (your fees 10%, company fee 7% — HAVC caps it there, verified NN 144/2014 — insurance/legal/E&O 3%, publicity 4%) · **contingency ~ 9–10%** (0% contingency reads amateur, not efficient). Editing alone: ~1 month per 10 finished minutes (~9 months for 90'), doubled tendencies for vérité. Delivery package €25–60k. E&O €10–20k for our risk profile. Archival at commercial rates ~ \$50–80/second — get 2023-footage quotes NOW, in development, not in the online.

The two-budget strategy (be honest about scale): real HAVC doc grants run €40–90k per film; Croatian creative docs commonly finish at €300–600k. Your €1.2–1.5M is IDFA-Forum-upper-cluster scale and only closes with the full international stack. So build both: **Budget A "the core film" ~€700–800k** — closable with HAVC + HRT + one minority partner + Eurimages + rebate + sponsors; the film exists with certainty. **Budget B "the ambition" €1.2–1.5M** — adds the second partner, bigger post, archive buy-ups, score recording, delivery war chest; unlocked by streamer/EP/market money. Every financier respects a producer who shows the film exists at A and gets bigger at B. Nobody funds a plan where the film dies without the last, least likely euro.

7 · The financing stack (three lanes, sequenced)

Lane 1 — soft money (the foundation, 50–70%): HAVC production (10 Sept; with co-producer on the prijavnica because čl. 7 scores their last 3 films) > HRT pre-sale (LOI now, call ~Dec–Feb) > IT/HU minority partners bringing their national funds > **Eurimages** (docs: <=25% of budget, cap €500k; needs >=2 member-state producers, >=50% financing confirmed per country at filing, deferrals+in-kind count <=15%; >€150k is a repayable advance from first-euro receipts at its financing share) > **Croatian rebate 25%+5%** (docs min spend €60k; apply >=8 days before a production block WITH proof of 70% financing; pays after audit + ~90 days > it finances post/delivery, never the shoot) > city/county culture calls (€3–10k tier) > Whickers/Doc Society/Field of Vision (US-FUNDS.md). **Ceiling check:** GBER caps total public aid ~50% of budget, 60% for cross-border co-pros — HAVC legal confirms the math. **Lane 2 — brands (the shoot-saver):** Mares (warm via Sanda) · Molchanovs

(Lastovo teaches their curriculum) · Garmin (owns no freediving story) · Croatian pride tier · US road-trip barter (RV, GoPro). Keep <10–15% of budget, contracted as content/credits, never touching the cut, disclosed consistently. **Lane 3 — the market (the endgame):** sales agent MG/pre-sales from rough cut · streamer acquisition post-premiere (\$300k–1.5M realistic band) · Croatian theatrical + adventure tours + windowed digital as the no-streamer floor. **Not in the stack:** equity and gap debt. Every euro of them sits above you in the waterfall forever; at doc revenue levels they usually ARE the entire net. Your no-cheap-equity instinct is arithmetic, not stubbornness.

Paper your own money — now, per the DPA waterfall rules: as financier of your own film you must treat yourself with the same formality as a stranger. The Documentary Producers Alliance framework: deferred fees (up to their budgeted amounts) recoup **first** from first income, or convert to sweat equity recouping alongside investors at the same premium; every participant at a tier is paid pro rata pari passu; and **soft money you raised counts toward your share of net profits**. Also note the DPA credit tiers your future EPs will expect: financing $\geq 50\%$ of budget = Presentation credit + up to 4 EP credits; $\geq 20\%$ = "In Association with" + up to 2; $\geq 10\%$ = one EP credit — while working credits (Producer/Co-/Associate) may never be bought or sold. Document your ~€35k+ contribution and your deferred fees this way today, so no later investor can accidentally (or deliberately) subordinate you.

8 • Cash flow — the trough

Everything pays late: HAVC in milestone tranches, rebate after audit, Eurimages in instalments (then recoups), broadcasters on delivery, the streamer years from now. A "fully financed" €1.2M film still spends quarters at **-€100–200k** cumulative. Your defenses: (1) the **cumulative cash-flow worksheet** — build it with the financing plan, update monthly, show financiers (it reads as competence); (2) sequence shoots behind confirmed tranches; (3) bridge instruments — Croatian bank discounting against a signed HAVC contract or the rebate's provisional certificate; (4) deferring your own fees (the classic float — contractually, with a defined repayment trigger); (5) your €10–25k = the personal float for exactly Lastovo+USA, already gated. **Never float payroll taxes.**

9 • Waterfall & CAMA — where revenue actually goes

Order: CAM fee › agent commission (doc norm 20–25%; fight for 15–20%; >30% red flag) › agent's **capped** expenses › debt › Eurimages recoupment corridor › deferrals › net split among co-producers. Worked example: €500k of sales › ~€170k to the majority producer — normal, plan on it. **CAMA** (Freeway or Fintage; Eurimages has a Freeway framework): all buyers pay one neutral account, disbursed per the contract — the agent never touches your money. Written into the co-production agreement from day one; a sales agent who refuses a CAMA is telling you who they are.

10 • Company & chain of title

The film must be owned by the d.o.o., not by you-the-person. Every right flows to it in writing: **your own director agreement with your own company** (yes, really — copyright vests in authors; buyers look for this hole first), crew IP assignments (re-paper Krk/Sicily onto the company once

registered), releases, locations, music, archive, financing agreements. **The binder discipline:** every agreement filed the day it's signed, one-line index, producible in 24 hours. Chain of title is checked at four gates — E&O, treaty certification, and the sale twice. What breaks it: the unsigned release, the freelancer who never signed, festival-only music licenses, verbal co-pro promises, contracts signed personally.

11 • Releases & the 2023 chapter (the legal heart of this film)

- **Everyone recognizable** signs an appearance release **on the day of filming**. Camp students at Lastovo sign the one-pager between dives (RELEASES-DRAFT.md Annex C).
- **The four** sign life-story-style agreements: cooperation + personal archive licensing + exclusivity + **covenant not to sue** — the clause E&O underwriters love most. Control: **never cut approval**; the defensible middle we designed honors the working-paper promise as a *viewing + factual-correction right limited to the defined 2023 Chapter* — streamer-compatible and morally straight.
- **The blackout:** specific consent to that footage (Petar + safety divers + medics). Privacy ≠ defamation — true medical facts can still violate privacy. His post-blackout interview is the context that makes use of it honest.
- **The 2023 chapter protocol:** (1) the **annotation file** — every factual assertion in the cut footnoted to a document, on-record interview, or official finding; language discipline: adjudicated fact ("sanctioned under a code of ethics; tests negative") vs allegation; (2) **right of reply** — before lock, written summaries of the specific claims to the other side (organiser, CMAS), their response or "declined" in the film, correspondence archived; (3) **legal read of the fine cut before lock** — juxtaposition can defame even when every line is true; (4) E&O bound off the back of 1–3. Done early this LOWERS the premium; done late it forces post-lock recuts, the most expensive edits in film.

12 • Insurance & the contracts shelf

Two policies: production package per shoot (gear, liability, media; dive/marine riders for us) and **E&O** (\$1M/\$3M limits, 3-year term, €10–20k our profile, start the application at rough cut). **The shelf, each with its non-negotiable:** director agreement (assignment + defined cuts, financeable replacement clause) · crew deal memos (economic-rights assignment + consent to modifications — drafted for Croatian law, not US "work-for-hire" boilerplate; no-injunction clause) · composer package deal (company owns composition + master, or watertight all-media perpetual license; composer keeps PRO writer's share — free to you; **stems contractually delivered**) · editor agreement (defined cuts + overages + materials custody + post-lock services) · co-production agreement (shares, spend geography, waterfall, delegate producer, credits, CAMA, final cut protected) · sales agency agreement (commission, **hard expense cap €20–40k**, 7–10yr term with performance reversion, prize money excluded, no cross-collateralization, CAMA) · license agreements (holdbacks must fit the festival/HRT plan; 10% signature / 90% **on delivery**).

13 • Delivery — the thing that kills films (so it won't kill ours)

The buyer's delivery schedule = picture masters (texted AND **textless** — our lower-thirds/depth-counters/subtitles make the textless build real work: do it during the online) · 5.1 + stereo + **filled M&E** (vérité's trap: dialogue and ambience share the mic; the M&E must be *built during the mix* or it costs thousands later) · stems · timecoded bilingual dialogue/spotting list · CC/SDH · complete chain of title · E&O cert · cue sheet · credits/billing with **HAVC/Eurimages logo obligations** · 50–200 stills (**shot during production — Etna cannot be re-staged**) · layered key art · QC pass (fails on loudness, sync, archival artifacts, M&E holes; failed QC = 4–8 lost weeks). Realistic cost **€25–60k, 2–4 months**. Our prevention, standing orders: streamer spec in front of the post supervisor before any post contract; M&E/textless/stems/spotting in the sound-house and online deal memos; 5% of post held as delivery contingency; stills assigned on every remaining shoot starting Lastovo.

14 • Post-production as strategy (not just craft)

Paper edit from the interview architecture (the five returning questions ARE the string-out structure — the app's interview library is built for this) › assembly (editor hired Nov–Dec; cut AWAY from your attachment: you shot it, the editor owes the footage nothing) › rough cut (spring 2027) › **feedback screenings**: small, structured, strangers included, written questions before discussion; run 2–3 of them — films that skip this premiere their blind spots › fine cut › edit lab window (IDFAcademy / Ex Oriente / Sundance Edit & Story Lab — labs are also where ARTE and agents fall in love) › **legal read** › lock › finishing. The bigger swings (physiological score, real-time dive, four-voices monologue) get tested at rough cut and killed without mercy if they don't play — the bible's own rule.

15 • Festival › sale mechanics

Premiere status is currency: world > international > European; a top-tier world premiere is bought once and never refunded — nothing public before the premiere festival clears it. The exact rules (verified): Sundance competition = world premiere, ANY prior public exhibition kills it; TIFF = North American premiere minimum, "public" = advertised/ticketed; **IDFA allows up to two prior festival screenings and even a home-country theatrical/TV release** — the one flexibility in the system, useful if the Croatian release ever needs to move early. Private, unadvertised feedback screenings never count. Budget a **festival publicist (\$5–15k per major festival)** for the premiere — reviews and trade coverage at the premiere are literally sales collateral. **The sequence**: IDFA Forum (Nov 2026, film unfinished — financing room, not premiere) › agent courted from sizzle, formally attached at rough cut (they now board early and may bring money/editorial notes — normal, cap their expenses) › Cannes Docs market screenings (May 2027; market ≠ premiere, status safe) › **world premiere Telluride/TIFF Sept 2027** (Plan B: Tribeca June; Plan C: CPH:DOX/IDFA 2027 as premiere instead of European slot) › buyers watch at the festival and on screeners; deals close **months after** — *All That Breathes* won Sundance and sold to HBO four months later; at Sundance 2026 not a single doc deal closed during the festival and the industry line is deals now "take up to a year" — so no in-festival bidding panic, the agent works the room and the finance plan never depends on a fast sale › then the genre circuit with no status cost: Banff (> world tour), Kendal, ocean tours, FICTS — the *Alpinist* long-tail engine › Croatian theatrical event release (four national heroes = real

domestic box office) › windowed digital if no global buy. **Buyers, ranked for us:** Netflix (bought freediving twice; Deepest Breath ~8M views/2 wks; acquisitions via Del Deo, sports via Spitzer — access+stakes+characters is their stated triad) · Nat Geo (Free Solo/Rescue heritage) · HBO/Max · ARTE La Lucarne / ZDF / YLE via the co-producer · Red Bull Studios as co-financier (price = control). **Pitch as adventure-thriller-with-heart in the Free Solo lane — never "issue doc," never "another Deepest Breath"** (ours: alive, present-tense, ensemble, vindication).

16 • The EP move

The Deepest Breath sold to Netflix before its premiere because of the package (Battsek/A24). Our equivalent: after the premiere strategy is set and the sizzle is strong, ask the sales agent to matchmake **one respected adventure-doc EP** (the Chin/Vasarhelyi, Noah Media, Ventureland tier). Cost: a fee and a credit. Return: the streamer's phone answers. Timing: rough cut, from strength — never now, at maximum weakness.

17 • The traps, each with its guard (first-timer killers › Deep Dive answers)

1. **Overshooting without structure** › the five returning questions are the structure; log/select after every block in the app; paper edit before the editor arrives.
2. **Missing paper** › releases at Lastovo; binder discipline; re-paper Krk/Sicily; lawyer this month.
3. **Post & delivery unbudgeted** › the 30%-after-the-shoot rule; €25–60k delivery line; 5% delivery contingency — in Budget A, not just B.
4. **No E&O until the buyer asks** › application at rough cut; annotation file grows from Lastovo onward, not retro-fitted.
5. **Blown premiere status** › nothing from the film public pre-premiere; sizzle stays in private links; BTS social ≠ film footage.
6. **No sales strategy until the film is done** › agent conversations start at IDFA 2026 with the sizzle.
7. **Money runs out in post** › cash-flow worksheet monthly; rebate banked for post; edit begins only with the edit financed.
8. **The uncapped sales agent / cross-collateralization / no CAMA** › §12 checklist; walk away is a position.
9. **Solo-producer burnout** › the delegation ladder (§2) is calendared like a deadline: PM days by August, co-producer by September, editor by November.
10. **The sensitive chapter handled late** › right-of-reply and legal read are IN the schedule (pre-lock), owned, budgeted.

18 • Operating cadence (how you run this from tomorrow)

- **The producer hour, daily at fixed time:** paper, money, email — before creative work eats the day.

- **Weekly:** cash position vs worksheet · pipeline (every open application/conversation, one line each) · binder check (what got signed this week?).
- **Per shoot block:** pre-block (insurance, permits, releases printed, stills assigned, two-copies backup rule) · post-block (footage logged, releases filed, costs reported, one-page "what the film gained" note).
- **Monthly:** cost report (budget vs actual vs estimate-to-complete) — the habit that makes HAVC/Eurimages audits trivial and financiers calm.
- **The app is the production office:** schedule, contacts, releases tracker, interview library, sponsor pipeline, archive log. What isn't in the system doesn't exist.

19 · This week (14–25 July) — the sprint, restated once more

1. **Sizzle** (team cuts, you direct) › 2. **d.o.o. "OneMasterTake" + Očevidnik filed** › 3. **IDFA Forum entry by the 24th** (draft ready, fill [TOMO] fields) › 4. **Releases to lawyer › print for Lastovo** › 5. **Email Vanja/Restart + ISHOF** › 6. **Lastovo shoot bible + stills plan + hydrophone/biolum test kit** › 7. Lastovo, 20th: shoot begins — and the producer hour survives the boat.

The film is the four of them holding each other in the dark. The production is you holding the film — with paper, money, and a calendar. Both are load-bearing. Idemo.

II

The Master Plan

Dated operating plan: deadlines, financing lanes, rights checklist, risks.

Producer's operating plan · compiled 12 July 2026 · companion to the Film Bible + DEEP_DIVE.md

Research verified 12 Jul 2026 (three research passes: funding / distribution / fact-check).

Unverified items are marked.

o · WHERE WE STAND (asset inventory)

Shot: Krk (done) (~16 interviews, dives, festival) · Sicily (done) (1–6 Jul) — with **Etna erupting inside the shoot window** (RED aviation alert 5 Jul, Catania airport closed — documented news event, archive licensable to augment our footage) and **Petar's blackout on the monofin attempt** (zero press footprint > we likely own the only footage of it). **Spent:** ~€10k, 100% Tomo. No equity sold. Full access + trust of the four. That's the leverage — protect it. **The story now:** Petar holds 3 of 4 absolute depth records (FIM 137m · CWTB 128m < *missing from the bible, add it* · CNF 103m). The missing one is CWT monofin — the Sicily miss. The film gained its opening (Etna), its wound (the blackout), and its ending (Vegas induction) this month.

Decisions locked 12 Jul (Tomo):

1. **Cyprus vs USA** > depends on the four; plan BOTH variants until they confirm (ask at Lastovo).
 2. **Company** > not started; found the d.o.o. + Očevdник NOW.
 3. **Bridge budget** > €10–25k of Tomo's capital for Lastovo + USA; sponsors close the rest.
 4. **Releases** > nothing signed; draft HR/EN this week, sign at Lastovo.
-

1 · THE STRATEGY IN ONE PARAGRAPH

Finish shooting the year (Lastovo > USA > Cyprus-variant > Rijeka lab > coda) on lean self+sponsor money **without selling any equity**, while building the institutional engine in parallel: d.o.o. + Očevdник now, **IDFA Forum entry by 25 July, HAVC production rok 10 September**, foreign co-producer (Italy and/or Hungary) locked by winter, Eurimages once the co-pro exists, 25%+5% rebate on the Croatian spend + post. Sales agent courted from the sizzle onward (MetFilm Sales first). Picture lock spring–summer 2027. World premiere **Telluride/TIFF Sept 2027** (Plan A) or Tribeca Jun 2027 (Plan B), European premiere IDFA 2027, streamer deal closed by an agent off the premiere — realistic band \$300k–\$1.5M, outliers higher with awards heat. Netflix takes no cold pitches (verified) — the agent/EP IS the door.

2 · THE CLOCK — dated actions

NOW › 25 July (the two-week sprint)

Deadline	Action	Notes
ASAP	Cut the sizzle (3–5 min: Etna opening › Krk bonds › Sicily attempt/blackout-tease › Vegas tease)	The asset every other line depends on. Decide who edits TODAY.
ASAP	Found the d.o.o. (with Luka per bible) + court register, NKD 59.11	e-osnivanje takes days; €2,500 min capital (or j.d.o.o. €1 to start fast — check HAVC acceptability)
ASAP +15d lead	Očividnik producenata application (ocevidnici.havc.hr, ocevidnici@havc.hr)	15-day lead; gate for ALL HAVC money
25 Jul 23:59 CEST	IDFA Forum entry (€30; professionals.idfa.nl)	Forum = 15–18 Nov, Amsterdam. For projects IN PRODUCTION — exactly us. ARTE/ZDF/YLE/BBC + sales agents in one room. Needs: logline, synopsis, promo link, budget + finance plan, producer info. <i>The bible's "15 Aug" is stale — festival film entry closed 9 Jul; Forum closes 25 Jul.</i>
Before Lastovo (~20 Jul)	Releases drafted (HR/EN participant release + life-story rights; lawyer pass)	Sign during camp weeks. 2023 chapter: limited approval right over that chapter only — NOT general final cut (streamer-compatible).
Before Lastovo	Lastovo shoot bible (Sicily-bible format)	Camps confirmed: 20–26 Jul · 26 Jul–2 Aug · 2–9 Aug, Zaklopatica, Adriatic Freediving (Vito's outfit, Molchanovs curriculum)
This week	Email ISHOF / Dr. Goldman's office	Confirm class list (Kasparov!), request filming permission 26 Sept ceremony, Palms Grand Ballroom. No public filming policy exists — ask, don't assume. Route via Toni/Select PR if useful.

August (Lastovo weeks — shoot + apply)

- **Shoot Lastovo** (the deep 2023 sit · the sport laid bare · Borna's arc if still in · sign releases · ask the four the Cyprus question).
- **Prepare HAVC production application** for the **10 Sept rok** (dugometražni dokumentarni; avg award ~€52k/film, 6 of 16 funded last round). Track record is scored › **attach an established Croatian co-producer/производитель** to the application if at all possible.
- Sponsor wave 1 with the sizzle: **Mares** (warm via Sanda — confirmed her sponsor) › **Molchanovs** (Zsófia is their athlete; Lastovo teaches their curriculum — the camp is literally their product) ›

Garmin (no flagship freediving story exists — we're it; Descent G2 has apnea modes) › Croatian pride tier (HTZ, Jamnica/Jana, HT, Rimac). Ask = cash for USA block + gear; give = credits, content spinoffs, event presence. **Never final cut.**

- USA production prep: ESTA/visas, RV quote (Vegas›SF per app bible), kit carnet, US production insurance, venue/event permissions, Kasparov team contact for release.

September–October

- **10 Sept:** HAVC production application IN (+ međunarodna suradnja same day for IDFA travel money if eligible).
- **USA tour** (3 weeks around **26 Sept, Palms Hotel Vegas** — Olympia weekend 24–27 Sept). Cover: induction (vindication beat — possible film opening per "Surface to the ending, then sink"), Kasparov moment if released, RV road trip, side events, maybe the coda dive.
- **Cyprus variant** if the four say yes: AIDA Depth Worlds, **Limassol 27 Sept–10 Oct** — collision with Vegas (Vito can't do both). Variant A: skip, world-stage beat = Lastovo comp. Variant B: split team (second shooter with Petar/Zsófia). Variant C: USA compressed › Limassol finale (~8–10 Oct).
- **CPH:FORUM submission opens Sept, closes early Nov** — our fallback/second market if IDFA Forum says no.

November–December

- **IDFA (12–22 Nov) + Forum (15–18 Nov)** — Amsterdam. Even if not selected: attend on industry pass (HAVC travel support), meet sales agents with sizzle v2 (now incl. Vegas). Priority order: **MetFilm Sales** (made+sold *Last Breath* — closest precedent), **Dogwoof**, **Autlook**; US route: Submarine / Cinetic. They now board at rough-cut with money — that's normal.
- **HRT** doc editorial meeting (their 2027 co-production call lands ~Dec–Feb; LOI now, offer when it opens).
- **WEMW Trieste deadline ~Oct · East Doc Platform ~Nov** · lock the **foreign minority co-producer**: Italy first (Sicily spend already exists; WEMW is their turf; Sanda's Trieste link), Hungary parallel (Zsófia › NFI minority scheme). This unlocks **Eurimages** (>=2 countries, docs >=70', up to 25% of budget / €500k — the single biggest cheque available).
- Rijeka/Zagreb lab shoot + **Filming-in-Croatia rebate application >=8 days before** that block (25%+5%; docs min qualifying spend €60k — clear it by bundling remaining Croatian shoots + the whole edit/post done in Croatia. Krk/Lastovo spend before the company existed is likely lost to the rebate — cost of starting late, accept and move).

2027

- **Jan–Mar:** edit (assembly › rough). Eurimages deadline #1 (early Jan, verify) with co-producer. ZagrebDox Pro (~Feb, free, home turf) · East Doc Platform (Mar) · **CPH:FORUM (14–18 Mar)**.
- **Spring:** rough cut › sales agent formally attached › **Cannes Docs market screenings (May)** — warms buyers without burning premiere.
- **Sept 2027: WORLD PREMIERE — Telluride or TIFF Docs** (TIFF deadline ~May 2027). Fallbacks: Tribeca Jun 2027 (deadline ~Dec 2026–Jan 2027, rough cut OK), Hot Docs (Ontario-premiere-only rule = flexible). **European premiere: IDFA 2027** (entry ~Jul 2027). Then DOC NYC (the *14 Peaks* springboard).

- **Post-premiere:** streamer deal (agent-led). If no global buy by late 2027 › split rights: Nat Geo/HBO Max territories + ARTE La Lucarne/ZDF/YLE + Croatian event-theatrical (four national heroes = real box office at home) + **Banff/Kendal/Ocean world tours** (revenue + the *Alpinist* long-tail engine) + windowed YouTube endgame (Patagonia/Yes Theory model — the freediving community is huge online).
- Sundance 2027: **skip** (lock too late + total premiere purity required). Sundance 2028 only if we deliberately hold the film — we won't.

3 • MONEY MAP (three lanes, don't confuse them — per bible §12)

Lane 1 — Sponsors/brands (fast, no equity): funds the remaining shoots. Tiers per bible + new intel: Mares (WARM), Molchanovs (natural fit), Garmin (open lane, no freediver flagship), Suunto/Shearwater, Croatian pride (HTZ, Jamnica, HT, Rimac, banks), wild metaphor tier (Whoop/Oura — the 20bpm heart; watch brands — depth+time). Sponsor gets: credits, content series, event presence, athlete association. Sponsor never gets: final cut, the 2023 chapter. **Lane 2 — Institutional (slow, structural):** HAVC production (10 Sept; ~€50k class) › HRT (LOI › 2027 call) › foreign co-producer(s) (IT/HU) › their national funds + **Eurimages** (<=€500k) › Creative Europe (parked — new company ineligible until Deep Dive is delivered; then Mini-Slate 2028) › rebate 25%+5% on Croatian spend incl. post › city/county culture calls autumn (Rijeka/PGŽ/Zagreb, €3–10k tier, local legitimacy). **Lane 3 — Market (the endgame):** sales agent MG/presales after rough cut › streamer acquisition post-premiere (\$300k–\$1.5M realistic band) › Red Bull Studios as possible co-financier (price = control; handle carefully) › Croatian theatrical + tours + windowed digital. **Dead:** Al Jazeera Balkans ceased operations 2025 — remove from all thinking.

Bridge budget (Tomo's €10–25k, decision-gated):

- Lastovo ~ €8–12k (Tomo-led; 1 shooter on peak days ~10 paid days €2.5k; lodging/boat/travel; NP permits).
- USA ~ €10–14k lean (2 people: flights ~€1.6k, RV 3wk ~€3.5k, fuel/camps ~€1.5k, insurance ~€1k, per diems, Vegas nights).
- Cyprus variant B adds ~€3–5k (one shooter + flights) — only if the four confirm competing.
- Gate: if a sponsor closes >=€10k before 1 Sept, upgrade USA crew; if nothing closes, USA runs at floor spec.

4 • RIGHTS & LEGAL (streamer-delivery reality — start now)

1. **Participant releases + life-story rights** — the four + supporting cast + family. 2023 chapter: contractually honor the working-paper promises as a **limited approval right over the 2023 chapter only** (veto on that chapter's cut), never general final cut — otherwise no streamer E&O passes. Lawyer required.
2. **Krk tournament footage** — "we receive all footage" › get it IN WRITING (license from organizer).
3. **Blue World / Sicily UW footage** — license paper.

4. **The 2023 search video** (secretly filmed, posted online) — using it = defamation/privacy/copyright review. Truth defense is strong (negative WADA tests, ITA no-violation, the Škerbić 2025 paper) but this is exactly what **E&O insurance + media lawyer** exist for. Budget it.
 5. **Language discipline:** always "cleared by negative WADA-lab tests; punished via a three-page Code of Ethics; no doping violation" — never "doping conviction." Legally material, verified.
 6. **ISHOF ceremony** — venue (Palms) + ISHOF media permission; **Kasparov appearance release** if he features beyond incidental (his team must sign; treat him as bonus, never spine).
 7. Guinness/AIDA/CMAS archive licensing list · music · drone rules (EU + FAA Part 107 for USA) · US filming status for crew (ESTA/B-1 gray zone — get advice before booking).
 8. **Deal memos** for all crew (work-for-hire, rights to the production company once it exists — re-paper Krk/Sicily crew work onto the new d.o.o.).
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5 • TEAM GAPS (honest)

- **Croatian co-producer with HAVC track record** — the single highest-value attach before 10 Sept. Neutralizes track-record scoring, carries finance/admin so Tomo directs. **Shortlist done > COPRODUCER-SHORTLIST.md: Restart first call (Fiume o morte! = Rijeka + Italy + Eurimages playbook), then Wolfgang & Dolly, Hulahop.** Key: HAVC Pravilnik čl. 7 scores the producer's last 3 films > partner must sign the prijavnica as co-producer, not a support letter.
- **Editor with feature-doc credits** — financiers fund editors almost as much as directors. Attach by rough-cut phase at latest.
- **International EP** — the *Deepest Breath* lesson: the Netflix deal rode on Battsek/A24 package. One respected adventure-doc EP name changes everything. Ask sales agents' advice at IDFA — they love making these matches.
- Media lawyer (releases, E&O) · post house (Zagreb — rebate-eligible spend) · festival PR (2027, not now).
- Athletes' PR = Toni/Select PR — keep separated from the film's PR (bible principle, still correct).

6 • RISK REGISTER

1. **Blackout footage consent** — Petar must see and approve how the blackout is used before it's in any sizzle shown outside the room. It's also ammunition for post-2023 trolls — context is everything. Handle at Lastovo, gently, per the working-paper promises.
2. **No releases yet** — everything is goodwill until Lastovo signing. Top priority.
3. **Deadline stack 25 Jul / 10 Sept** — both fail if the sizzle and company registration slip this week.
4. **Kasparov** — same-class induction is Medium-High confidence (no primary ISHOF page opened); verify with ISHOF before building scenes on it.
5. **Cyprus collision** — resolved only by the four (Lastovo conversation).
6. **Competitor journalist manuscript** — outpace with footage-in-hand + signed exclusivity (the releases).
7. **Tomo burnout / solo-everything** — director+producer+DP+editor+investor+app-dev is not a 2027 plan. The autumn co-producer attach is the fix; calendar it like a deadline.

8. **Market reality** — doc acquisitions are slow and selective (zero in-festival Sundance 2026 buys). The plan survives a no-streamer outcome via split rights + tours + home theatrical. Build Plan A distribution muscles anyway.

7 • APP (Deep Dive V1.1) — production OS tasks

- Deploy to Vercel (shared URL for crew/the four) — already in app backlog.
- Enter into Schedule: Lastovo camps (20 Jul–9 Aug), HAVC roks (10 Sept), IDFA Forum (25 Jul deadline; 15–18 Nov event), ISHOF (26 Sept), AIDA Worlds (27 Sept–10 Oct), CPH:FORUM (early Nov deadline).
- Data corrections: add Petar CWTB 128m; correct IDFA date everywhere; mark Al Jazeera Balkans dead in any sponsor/buyer lists.
- Contracts view: track release signatures per person at Lastovo.

8 • OPEN QUESTIONS (for Tomo, non-blocking)

1. Who cuts the sizzle — Tomo, Luka, or an outside editor? Is Sicily footage ingested/backed up ×2 and logged?
2. The blackout conversation with Petar — when/how do you want to have it? (Before the sizzle goes anywhere.)
3. d.o.o. details for founding: name, ownership split with Luka, who administers?
4. Any existing relationship to Croatian doc producers for the co-producer attach — or should I build the shortlist?
5. Kasparov contact route — via ISHOF office, or does Vito's PR have a channel?
6. Freediving game + this film: park the game until post-Lastovo (hero-guardrail), or brief it as transmedia in the Forum application?

9 • USA LEG — SERVICES CHECKLIST (no co-production; keep equity clean)

US money enters ONLY as: sponsorship / license-presale / service deal / grant. Never core copro equity while Eurimages is live (non-European share cap ~30%, "European work" status must survive — verify clause when structuring).

- ☐ Fixer/line producer day-rates: Vegas ceremony day + SF permit days
- ☐ US production insurance + COIs (Palms WILL require certificate before cameras enter; casino floors = casino approval, no exceptions)
- ☐ Permits: LVCVA (Vegas public areas), casino property approvals, SF Film Commission
- ☐ Visa/gear advice: ESTA vs B-1 for foreign crew + kit through customs — 1hr with advisor BEFORE booking flights
- ☐ RV barter pitch (vehicle for credit + content) — Cruise America / El Monte class; plus Garmin US / GoPro / Insta360 for the road-trip content block
- ☐ ISHOF permission (in motion) + Kasparov team release route
- ☐ US doc grants research › see US-FUNDS report (agent running 12 Jul)

Artifacts produced: IDFA-FORUM-ENTRY-DRAFT.md · RELEASES-DRAFT.md · COPRODUCER-SHORTLIST.md. Next on request: Lastovo shoot bible · Vanja/Restart outreach email (HR) · ISHOF email (EN) · sponsor one-pager · d.o.o./Očevdnik founding checklist · HAVC application skeleton.

III

Co-Producer Shortlist

Croatian partners ranked, with the HAVC prijavnica mechanics.

Researched 12 July 2026 (HAVC results PDFs 2024–2026 + Pravilnik + press). Goal: experienced co-producer on the 10 Sept HAVC prijavnica; Tomo keeps majority + final cut.

THE ADMINISTRATIVE KEY (from HAVC's Pravilnik)

- **Čl. 7 t. 2:** the application is scored partly on **the producer's previous 3 films** (festivals, admissions, sales). A support letter is worth ~nothing — the experienced company must sign the prijavnica **as co-producer** for their record to count.
- **Čl. 6:** applicant = independent producer in the Očevidnik, applying **jointly with the director**, with secured rights. Nothing forbids two Croatian co-producers on one project.
- **No majority-share rule found** between Croatian partners in the national category (majority/minority language exists only for international minority copros, čl. 34–38). **Verify with HAVC legal before 10 Sept: can the co-producer's filmography carry the scoring when the applicant d.o.o. is new?** (ocevidnici@havic.hr / HAVC pravna služba)
- **Čl. 8:** production-company fee capped at **7%** of the financial plan.
- Caveat: the public Pravilnik PDF predates the euro; the operative 2026 call text sits behind the portal — confirm clauses when the application account is open.

TOP 3 — approach in this order

1 • RESTART (Zagreb) — Vanja Jambrović / Tibor Keser / Oliver Sertić * THE CALL

- *Fiume o morte!* (Bezinović, 2025): **Rotterdam Tiger + FIPRESCI** (first Croatian film ever), **European Film Award — Documentary (Jan 2026)**, Croatia's Oscar submission, most-watched HR doc since independence.
- Financing architecture = literally ours: **HR/IT/SI copro, Eurimages €140k, Creative Europe, FVG fund, City of Rijeka** — and it's a **Rijeka film**. They know every desk we need.
- Doc-native house (Dokukino, doc school, distribution), director-first culture.
- Contact: restart@restarted.hr · Vanja Jambrović vanja@restarted.hr, +385 91 89 30 675 · oliver@restarted.hr
- Risk: post-EFA demand — pitch early, concrete, with the sizzle.

2 • WOLFGANG & DOLLY (Zagreb) — Tamara Babun Zovko

- Most consistently HAVC-funded doc shop 2024–26 (IDENTITET €70k · Lucić doc €61k · short €30k · plus €1.08M fiction). CineLink Rough Cut Boutique 2025.

- Eurimages paperwork experience as minority on *Body* (Seliškar). Babun: EURODOC, Ex Oriente, IDFA Academy.
- Best "finance/admin muscle per ego" ratio. Contact via wolfgangdolly.com (Vinkovićeva 15).

3 • HULAHOP (Zagreb) — Dana Budisavljević + Matea Milić

- HAVC doc grant Jun 2026 (€65k); *Diary of Diana B.* 35k HR admissions; house built to serve director-driven personal films.
- Italy line: co-produced with **Stefilm (Torino)** for ZDF/ARTE, RAI, HRT. Six-person office = real admin.
- Contact: ured@hulahop.hr.

BACKUPS

- **Fade In** — producing a sea doc right now (*Na morskome plavom žalu*, €80k Jun 2026); Beldocs 2026 winner; udruga/collective structure. office@fadein.hr
- **Factum (Puhovski)** — 80+ docs, ZagrebDox founder, DOK Leipzig Golden Dove 2025; maximum credibility, institution temperament, mostly domestic financing.
- **Petnaesta umjetnost (Osvadić)** — the purest producer-serves-auteur model (13 films with Dević, incl. water docs); small, no Eurimages. Good second co-producer.
- **Pipser (Čogelja)** — Producers on the Move 2023, superb EU network; no recent HAVC doc production grant.
- **Rijeka add-on: Filmaktiv** — only verified Rijeka doc producer (€79k Jun 2026); community/education profile, zero Eurimages › local partner alongside a Zagreb lead, not lead.
- **Split wildcard: Marinis Media** — *Nun of Your Business*; €65k Dec 2025; co-develops with **Alessio Bozzer, Trieste** (Italy line). Director-producer with her own slate.
- **Kinoteka** — *Dražen* (2024): sports-legend box-office hit, SI/RS/US copro — relevant to the Vegas/ISHOF angle, but fiction-first.

AVOID (for this project)

- **Nukleus** — internationally heavyweight, but highest power-balance risk for a first-timer keeping majority + final cut.
- **Antitalent** — red-hot, zero bandwidth (Pek also runs Pula FF); doc output thin.
- **Gral, Terminal 3** — no doc track record found. "**Val**" (Rijeka) / "**Motion**" (Split) — could not verify these exist as doc producers; dead ends.

DEAL FRAME (proposal to bring to the first coffee)

Tomo's d.o.o. = majority rights-holder + delegates director's contract; partner = co-producer on the HAVC prijavnica (their filmography scores), fee within the 7% cap, defined scope: HAVC/Eurimages administration, HRT + foreign copro negotiation, festival/finance strategy. Creative control + final cut stay with the director (2023 chapter approval sits with the four per the working paper — non-negotiable). Sequence: Restart coffee ASAP with sizzle › if slate-full, W&D + Hulahop in the same week › co-production agreement signed before the 10 Sept rok; name on IDFA Forum entry as "in

negotiation" if timing allows.

IV

US & International Funds Map

Grants open now, opening later, and confirmed dead ends.

Non-equity money open to a Croatian feature doc in production, delivery Q4 2027. Full agent research; deadlines verified where possible, "not verified" flagged.

OPEN NOW

Fund	What	Deadline	Verdict
Doc Society Fund (global)	Feature docs, "better futures" framing	Rolling EOI, open now (apply.doc society.org)	Strong — cheap EOI, global, ocean-advocacy framing fits. Do this month.
Field of Vision	Commissions features/shorts, any stage	Rolling, no deadlines (fieldofvision.org/submit)	Good — the 2023 sports-justice/accountability story is their lane. Low-hours pitch.
Pulitzer Center	Journalism/short docs only, \$5–10k	Rolling	Marginal — only as companion short on the justice case.
POV CFE 2027 season	PBS acquisition, ~\$30k–250k, rough cut+	Jul 31, 2026 (not verified on page)	Skip this cycle (no rough cut) > target mid-2027 CFE for 2028 season. CPB defunded = US public TV money at risk.

OPENS LATER (calendar these)

- **The Whickers — £120,000 main award** (whickerawards.com): worldwide, **director's first 50'+ doc** — literally Tomo's profile. Next round ~Nov 2026–Jan 2027. (!) **Caps: budget <=£500k, other funding <=£350k — our €1.2M envelope breaches this. Pre-check email decides if it's alive (stage question too: "late dev/early production")**. Highest single-cheque EV if the caps question resolves.
- **Ford JustFilms** — \$100–200k, global, social-justice; fall open call (~Oct–Dec, 2026 dates not announced). Watch from Sept.
- **Sundance Documentary Fund** — \$50–100k prod/post, global; 2027 window closed Jun 2026; next May–Jun 2027 > notifies ~2028, only useful if delivery slips.
- **Sundance x Sandbox Fund** (science docs) — physiology-at-depth fits; next ~spring 2027. Also watch Sandbox x CPH:DOX Science Pitch Award 2027.
- **Points North Fellowship** — worldwide, early-career; ~Jan–Mar 2027 deadlines; Sept 2027 = edit-stage timing. Calendar it.

- **Doc Society Climate Story Fund** — \$40–125k; **2026 closed Jul 6 — missed by 6 days**; get on list for 2027 (materials double with the EOI above).
- **AFS Sports Documentary Residency (USC)** — 12 international filmmakers, US sports-media pitch access; 2027 edition unconfirmed (State-Dept funded). Watch Nov 2026.
- **Save Our Seas Ocean Storytelling Grant** — \$50k but SHORT film commission; viable companion short with Vito; next ~Nov 2026.
- IDA Pare Lorentz — themed + needs experienced team member; low priority. Nat Geo Society RFPs — watch, ocean/human-limits themes recur.

CLOSED / INELIGIBLE (don't waste hours)

Chicken & Egg (gender eligibility) · IDA Enterprise (paused) · ITVS (US-only + CPB collapse) · Threshold (invite-only) · BFI Doc Society (UK-only) · Hot Docs Blue Ice (Africa-only) · **IDFA Bertha (Croatia excluded — EU/MEDIA country)** · Cinereach (no submissions) · True/False True Life (pays subjects, not filmmakers) · **Sloan (docs ineligible — fiction only)** · Simons/Sandbox Films & HHMI (studios — pitch as industry, not grants) · Religion of Sports/Uninterrupted (commissioners via reps) · IOC/OFCH (no open grants; freediving not Olympic) · Redford Center (needs US team member; next 2028) · Waitt/Schmidt/Patagonia/Save The Waves (no open film funds verified).

TOP 3 THIS QUARTER (agent's ranking, endorsed)

1. **Whickers prep** — pre-check email NOW (budget caps + stage), taster reel, proposal draft ready for ~Nov opening.
2. **Doc Society Fund EOI** — submit this month; few hours; materials reusable for Climate Story Fund 2027.
3. **Build the Documentary Core Application package once** (synopsis, treatment, bios, USD budget, sample reel — the IDA/Sundance standard format JustFilms also uses) › every future US deadline becomes a one-day job. Then fire Field of Vision as the package's first live test; be ready the day JustFilms opens.

Calendar beyond: AFS watch (Nov 2026) · Save Our Seas short (Nov 2026) · Points North (Jan–Mar 2027) · Sundance/Sandbox (Apr–Jun 2027, contingency) · POV (Jul 2027 › 2028 season).

V

Research: The Producing Craft

Stages, roles, the dual-hat problem, post workflow, festival mechanics.

Full research report, 14 July 2026. Companion to PRODUCER-MASTER-STRATEGY.md.

US/EU industry figures from cited sources; synthesized models flagged.

1. The stages, end to end

Financing is not a stage — it's a ladder through all stages: development money funds the teaser > teaser unlocks production money > early rough cut unlocks post money, with stops and self-funded gaps between (IDA 2025 budgeting intro). *The Silence of Others*: a 7-year funding journey; major partners came only after a great 15-min work sample. **You don't schedule a doc with one greenlight — you schedule gates, each unlocked by material (teaser > footage > rough cut).**

Durations: development 6–18 mo · production driven by the story's real-world clock · **editing ~1 month per 10 finished minutes > ~9 months for 90'** (Alliance of Documentary Editors), complex vérité "well over a year" · finishing ~12 weeks + **4 weeks deliverables** (IDA) · festival run 6–18 mo · **premiere > deal > release: "up to a year" in the current market** (IDA Sundance 2026 report) · impact campaigns need >=18 months (Screen Daily) · **58% of doc makers report 1–5 years total** (CMSI/IDA field study). Realistic whole-project calendar for a vérité doc shot across ~1 year: **~3 years from committed development to release.** Squeezed edit schedules "drive production costs much higher" (ADE) — the edit is the longest controllable stage and the one first-timers most catastrophically underestimate.

Model calendar (synthesis): months 0–6 development in parallel with opportunistic shooting (promo = the key asset; releases from day one) · 3–15 principal production, **transcribe/organize as you go — that's edit prep, not admin** · ~10–12 **assistant editor starts, months BEFORE the editor** (organizing, transcoding, grouping, syncing transcripts) · ~12–14 **editor starts "after the majority of footage is shot but while key shooting remains"** so the edit can still redirect shooting (ADE) · 12–21 the 9-month edit (watch-down at **2 hours of screening per 1 hour of footage**, string-outs, assembly ~month 3–4, rough cut ~6–7, feedback screenings, fine cut 8–9; sales agent talks from rough cut) · 21–24 lock > 12 wks finishing + 4 wks deliverables · 24–30 premiere + run (publicist 1–2 months pre-premiere) · 26–36 sale/delivery/impact.

2. Producer vs director; the dual-hat problem

Producer = the film as a business: funded, staffed, on time, on budget, delivered "according to the legal and technical standards required by its distribution" (PGA doc code of credits; DPA guidelines). Internal budget practice: Plan A (full rates) / Plan B (realistic) / Plan C (minimum viable); contingency

6–10%; director + producer fees 5–10% each (IDA).

Dual-hat failures: (1) on-set collapse — try to produce and direct on set and you end up producing, with no director on set (The Independent Film School); add DP in safety-critical freediving conditions and divided attention is a hazard, not an inefficiency. (2) Loss of objectivity — a separate producer gives notes from outside; the person who shot every frame is least able to kill a beautiful useless scene (Noam Kroll). (3) Financier-conflict — nobody protects the budget from the director's appetite; the standard failure is self-funding gaps + self-underpayment (IDA). (4) Burnout as schedule risk.

Delegation order as money arrives: 1) line producer/PM — the standard first hire ("hired early in pre-production... because the line producer creates and manages the budget" — Assemble/StudioBinder); rates \$5–15k/wk mid-budget, PM ~\$430/day (SetHero/Filmustage) — negotiate low-end/flat at doc scale but budget a real number. 2) assistant editor (months before editor). 3) editor. 4) production accountant/payroll (fringes vary by territory; financiers expect auditable cost reports). 5) specialists (archival producer, impact producer, publicist) at their natural stage.

3. Key roles, timing, cost anchors

- **Editor — the doc's second author, the most important hire.** ADE: "The Documentary Editor is also a writer" — no script; the editor writes every scene and the spine. Vasarhelyi (*Free Solo*): the editor is the closest collaborator, works like a writer on a narrative feature. Joe Bini: it might be 3 months before the first idea of what the story is. Hire: after majority shot, before wrap. Choose on **sensibility-match over CV** (Sam Green via Filmmaker Magazine); paid trial week on one scene. The edit is ~9 months of a senior creative — routinely the largest crew line. ADE working conditions: 8–9-hr days set by the editor, no weekends — crunch backfires.
- **Assistant editor:** starts months before the editor; "proper organization is one of the single most important factors in how quickly an editor can work" (ADE).
- **Archival producer:** as soon as archive matters — licensing takes months. Footage ~\$49–100+/sec; **TV news \$80–150/sec with 30-second minimums (\$2,400–4,500/clip)**; theatrical project minimums ~\$1,000 (Producers Library; documentarycameras.com; IDA archival guide).
- **Composer:** at fine cut; **~\$200–250 per minute of score > \$10–15k for 50 min**; commercial song licenses \$15–50k+ each (Saturation.io). Docs buy flat packages (writing + recording + stems).
- **Sound designer/re-recording mixer:** post-lock; doc post-audio ~£2–5k low end, features £4.5–13k (obodo); mix stages \$1–4k/day. A freediving film should spend ABOVE the doc norm here.
- **Colorist:** after conform; \$150–250/hr, 1–2 weeks for a feature.
- **Story consultant:** at assembly/rough-cut crises; e.g., Rough Cut Service (written dramaturgy feedback) — the cheapest editing time you'll buy.
- **Impact producer:** ~6 months pre-premiere; campaigns start at **\$15k minimum, need ~18 months** (Screen Daily; Impact Field Guide). Focused on change, not revenue.
- **Publicist/festival strategist:** 1–2 months pre-premiere; **\$5–15k per festival, \$7–12k at Sundance/TIFF-tier** incl. their travel (The Film Collaborative). Reviews at the premiere are sales collateral, not vanity.
- **Production accountant/payroll:** with first real financing.

Executive producers in docs — three species: (1) **money** — DPA tiers: financing $\geq 50\%$ of budget = Presentation credit + up to 4 EP credits; $\geq 20\%$ = "In Association with" + up to 2; $\geq 10\%$ = 1 EP credit (DPA crediting guidelines). (2) **Prestige/package** — a name that opens doors (sales agents themselves now take EP/financing roles — Variety). (3) **Broadcaster/commissioning EP**. The DPA insists working credits (Producer/Co-/Associate) "may not be bought, sold, or traded." **Creative producer** shares authorship and career-long ownership; **line producer** is a hired department head who executes and moves on. **DPA waterfall rules (paper your own money!):** deferred fees up to budgeted amounts recoup FIRST from first income, or convert to sweat equity recouping alongside investors at the same premium; each tier pro rata pari passu; **soft money you raised counts toward your share of net profits** (IDA/DPA waterfall guidelines). As financier-of-your-own-film, this is how you paper your investment so a later investor can't subordinate you.

4. Development

Treatment = the narrative document, present tense, as the film will feel; **8–15 pages standard** (DocFilmAcademy). Deck = the decision document: logline 25–40 words, synopsis, three acts, characters, visual identity, performing comparables, team, budget/finance plan, distribution strategy — tailored per audience (mission for foundations; comps/audience data for streamers). **Sizzle** (1–3 min, to 3–5 for investors) pitches the UNFINISHED film to industry; **trailer** sells the FINISHED film to audiences; teaser = shorter mood-first cousin. **Why the promo is the crown asset:** the only development artifact that proves rather than promises — access, cinematography, charisma, taste at once; it needs to persuade very few people to spend years and thousands on you (Documentary Television). **IDFA Forum takes projects at all stages EXCEPT rough cut** and wants strong visual material (IDFA) — 7 minutes in that room compresses a year of cold emails; the one-on-ones matter more than the public pitch. *Vérité* ≠ structureless: keep a living outline; bring the editor in early enough to flag which storylines lack coverage while you can still shoot.

5. Post-production

Workflow: AE ingest/organization (proxies, grouping, transcripts synced — before the editor starts) › watch-down at 2:1 + selects › **string-outs** (long chronological/thematic strings per character/scene) + paper edit › assembly (long, ugly, complete — 2–3× final length) › rough cut (structure works) › fine cut (scene polish, final music direction) › lock › conform, grade, sound design, **stereo + 5.1 mix, M&E** (note: Amazon and others often accept "mix minus" rather than fully-filled M&E for unscripted — check each buyer's spec), titles + **textless**, masters, captions, QC. IDA template: 12 weeks post + 4 weeks deliverables. **Feedback screenings, run deliberately:** three audiences — subject-matter experts, seasoned doc professionals, ~a dozen target-audience STRANGERS (not friends/family); slate missing GFX, label temp music; **written questionnaire completed BEFORE group discussion** (no opinion cross-contamination); someone else takes notes; weight convergent notes (New Doc Editing; Robin Piree; Frame.io). **Labs:** Sundance Doc Edit & Story Lab (assembly/rough-cut stage; travel covered; marks the film for programmers/funders) · IDFAcademy · **Ex Oriente Film** (IDF's year-long CEE program, partnered with DOK Leipzig — the natural lab for a Croatian producer) · Rough Cut Service (paid written consult) · **DAE — Documentary Association of Europe** (cheap membership, free monthly consulting, network). Labs solve the dual-hat objectivity problem with

senior outside eyes at exactly the assembly/rough-cut inflection, and put the film inside the referral network programmers and funders actually use.

6. Festival › sale mechanics

Premiere status = the one-shot resource. Sundance US Doc Competition: world premieres only; ANY prior public exhibition kills eligibility. TIFF: North American premiere minimum; "public screening" = advertised/ticketed with public or press. **IDFA: world/international/European premieres; allows max TWO prior festival/market screenings; national theatrical/TV at home is permitted.** Telluride: invitation-only, secret lineup; the classic Telluride › TIFF two-step. One advertised hometown "celebration screening" can demote you everywhere. Private, unadvertised feedback screenings are fine. **Sales agents** engage at rough cut and co-design the premiere; the sales team should exist months before the festival (No Film School/Cinetic). Commissions commonly 10–15% (to 20–35% full-service international); cap recoupable expenses (\$50–75k typical caps); keep terms short (3–5 yrs where possible) — an uncapped "cheap 15%" deal still destroys producer revenue (Raindance; FilmPlatforms 2026; Wrapbook). **How buyers buy:** industry office accreditation, P&I screenings, secure screeners; triage via first-screening reception + reviews. Bidding wars are the exception and manufacturing one is high-risk (Kaufman/Distribution Advocates). **Windows:** peak 2021 (*Summer of Soul* \$15M at Sundance) › normalized (*All That Breathes*: Sundance winner, sold to HBO 4 months post-premiere; *The Perfect Neighbor* › Netflix 2025) › **Sundance 2026: zero doc deals closed at the festival; deals "take up to a year"; "no urgency"; streamers avoid politically contentious material; treat alternative distribution (Kinema, Eventive, Gathr, event/impact screenings) as Plan A** (IDA Sundance 2026 report). A spectacle-driven, apolitical, international doc with a built-in global niche community is exactly the profile that still moves.

7. First-timer mistakes that kill docs

1. **Overshooting without structure** — every extra hour costs ~2 editor-hours of screening before anything else; discipline = living outline + early editor consults on what's MISSING.
2. **Missing releases / dirty chain of title** — paper as you shoot; it all surfaces at the E&O clearance report; chasing an estranged subject's release two years later is how films die at delivery.
3. **No E&O / insurance planning** — no release without it; \$1M/\$3M, ~\$10k deductible; doc policy ~\$3–4k (3-yr), contentious content more; under-declaring budget to shave premiums backfires on claims.
4. **No post/delivery budget** — post = 20–30% of total; the fixed delivery stack (E&O, DCP \$1.5–3.5k, CC \$500–2.5k + \$800–2k/language, QC \$500–2k, legal) = **\$10–35k minimum before marketing**; films that spend to lock literally cannot accept the distribution they win.
5. **Blown premiere status** — see §6.
6. **No sales strategy until the acceptance email** — team months before premiere; publicist 1–2 months out; screeners/key art/EPK ready. "It's harder to make a good sale later."
7. **Post-money exhaustion / self-exploitation** — the documented norm is self-funded gaps + self-underpayment; put your fee and deferral terms on paper NOW per DPA waterfall rules, while you're the financier — future investors respect paper, not memory.

8. **Burnout as production risk** — ADE codified humane hours because crunch backfires; the mitigation is structural: line producer, editor's authorship protected, labs as scheduled objectivity, the 3-year calendar budgeted honestly.

Key sources

IDA 2025 budgeting intro · ADE Guide for Documentary Edit Schedules (PDF) · DPA Crediting Guidelines + Waterfall Guidelines (via IDA/documentary.org) · PGA doc code of credits · CMSI/IDA State of the Documentary Field 2018 · IDA "Don't Panic" Sundance 2026 report · Sundance 2026 Submission Rules PDF · TIFF 2026 Submissions FAQ PDF · IDFA Entry Regulations · No Film School doc sales agents (Cinetic) · Distribution Advocates "Let's Make a Deal, or Not" · Sundance sales-agent reference list · IndieWire Sundance 2025 market pieces · Variety on sales agents › financiers · Raindance / FilmPlatforms 2026 / Wrapbook on agent terms · Front Row + Kelly + Film Emporium on E&O · SetHero/Assemble/StudioBinder/Filmustage on line producers · Filmmaker Magazine + New Doc Editing + Editors Guild on editors · Producers Library + IDA archival guide on footage costs · Saturation.io + obodo + Filmustage on post costs · Thoolie + Vitrina + Amazon Studios portal on delivery · New Doc Editing + Robin Piree + Frame.io on screenings · Sundance labs + Ex Oriente/DOK Leipzig + Rough Cut Service + DAE · DocFilmAcademy (treatment/deck/sizzle) + Documentary Television + IDFA Forum + IDA pitch-forum piece · Screen Daily + Impact Field Guide on impact · The Film Collaborative on festival PR · The Independent Film School + Noam Kroll on the dual-hat problem.

VI

Research: The Money Side

Budget anatomy, cash flow, waterfall, co-production and rebate mechanics.

Full research report, 14 July 2026. Companion to PRODUCER-MASTER-STRATEGY.md. All numbers cited; synthesized models labelled. Verify time-sensitive rules against primary sources before signing.

o. The mental model

A budget is a **cost plan**; a financing plan is a **list of promises**; cash flow is **when promises become money in the bank** — and the three never line up by themselves. European doc financing is mostly soft money that pays **late, in tranches, against milestones and audits**, while crew and travel must be paid **now**. The producer's real job is managing that gap without giving away the film.

1. How a feature doc budget breaks down

ATL vs BTL: Above-the-line = key creative costs (rights, development, producer/director/writer fees — where YOUR deferrable fees live). Below-the-line = hard costs (crew, equipment, travel, post, insurance, office). Docs are also cut **by phase** (development › production › editing › post/finishing › delivery/publicity) because funders finance phases, not whole films (IDA 2025 budgeting intro; Hot Docs budgeting guide).

Reference points (IDA 2025, real sample \$676,700 doc): R&D 12% · production 32% · editing 23% · post 25% · festivals/publicity 7%. **Editing + post = 48% — post is as large as the shoot on creative docs.** Director and producer fees ~ 5–10% of budget *each*; contingency 6–10% ("start at 10%, reduce reluctantly"); ~10% production-services fee normal on commissioned work. IDFA Forum 2023 projects averaged \$416–640k globally, ~\$900k US/UK, with clusters at \$200–500k and \$800k–1.4M — **€1.2–1.5M sits in the upper cluster; ambitious but normal for international co-produced cinema docs.**

Percentage model for a ~€1.2M creative feature doc (synthesized from IDA norms, adapted for expedition-heavy/low-archival):

Bucket	%	€
Development & research	4%	48,000
Producer + director fees (ATL, partly deferrable)	10%	120,000

Bucket	%	€
Production (crew, equipment incl. UW/safety, travel)	30%	360,000
Archival & footage licensing	3%	36,000
Editing (editor + assistant + suite, 9–12 months)	17%	204,000
Finishing (color/online, GFX, sound design + mix, M&E, DCP, deliverables)	10%	120,000
Music (composer + licensing)	3%	36,000
Insurance, legal, E&O, audit	3%	36,000
Publicity, festivals, stills, trailer	4%	48,000
Company overhead / production fee (HAVC cap 7%)	7%	84,000
Contingency	9%	108,000

The shape: production ~ 30%, everything after the shoot ~ 30%, and ~**25% is "invisible" money** (fees, overhead, insurance, contingency, publicity) that first-timers forget and then eat personally.

Post & delivery: 4–6 months of editing per ~120 hrs of footage, **double for vérité** (Fourwind Films); Alliance of Documentary Editors rule: ~1 month per 10 finished minutes > ~9 months for 90'. Color ~ 1–3 days per 10–20 finished min; dialogue edit ~ 1 wk per 30'; mix ~ 3 days per 30'. **Delivery package (master, DCP, 5.1+stereo, M&E stems, subs, CC, trailer, key art, cue sheets, chain of title, E&O cert): budget €10–25k+.** Broadcasters require closed captions (IDA "Don't Fudge on Your Budget").

Archival real prices: commercial archives \$49–79 **per second** (min license \$539–1,003/project — Producers Library) ~ \$3,000–4,700 per finished minute; per-clip \$149–499+. Price scales with term/territory/media. Trick: license festival-only cheap, budget the all-media buy-up as a delivery cost triggered by the sale — but it **MUST** be in the budget. For Deep Dive: even 5 min of agency news footage worldwide/all-media can be €20–50k. **Get quotes in development.**

Insurance: E&O mandatory for distribution — straightforward doc \$3–4k for 3-year policy, indie range \$2.5–10k at \$1M limits (Front Row, TH Agency); controversial content raises it. Production

package separate (IDA/HUB program exists). Completion bond 2–5% of budget but **rare in documentary** — know it exists for gap lenders only.

The two protected percentages: contingency ~10% (docs argue for more; 0% reads amateur, not efficient) and **company fee: HAVC hard cap 7% of total financial plan — verified in Pravilnik, NN 144/2014 čl. 8** (narodne-novine.nn.hr/clanci/sluzbeni/2014_12_144_2704.html; amendments at havc.hr/propisi). The 7% is how the company survives between films — always budget it fully; it is separate from the producer *fee* (ATL).

2. Cash flow — the thing that kills producers

"Financed" ≠ "funded". When cash actually arrives:

- **HAVC:** instalments against milestones (signature, start of shoot, rough cut, delivery/report) — never 100% upfront.
- **Croatian rebate:** AFTER wrap + audited accounts + up to 90 days (Invest Croatia) — realistically 6–12+ months after the money left your account.
- **Eurimages:** instalments tied to milestones; >€150k is an advance repaid from receipts.
- **Broadcaster pre-sale:** small % on signature, bulk **on delivery and technical acceptance**.
- **Sales MG / streamer:** on delivery of the finished, E&O-insured, QC-passed film — years away.
- **Sponsors:** against campaign milestones.

Real-world scale: a producer with a confirmed US network deal AND confirmed tax credits still faced a **\$2.5M shortfall** purely from timing gaps (Capitol Hill Times/GTF).

The trough (stylized Deep Dive quarters): a fully financed €1.2M film spends 2–4 quarters at **-€100–200k** cumulative position mid-production/edit, recovering only at rebate + delivery payments. Plan the trough or discover it as unpaid crew invoices. **Tool: cumulative cash-flow worksheet** (projected out vs in per month, running balance) — build it the day the financing plan is drafted, update monthly; financiers increasingly ask for it.

Instruments: bridge loan against a confirmed receivable (HAVC contract, pre-sale, rebate certificate — in Croatia often bank loan/factoring); gap financing against unsold-territory estimates at **12–20% interest** (rare for docs — lenders distrust doc estimates); deferrals (your own 10% fee = the classic first-timer float) — **Eurimages counts deferrals + in-kind as confirmed financing only up to 15% of budget**; in-kind (post house investing services); personal float (never float payroll taxes).

3. The financing plan & recoupment waterfall

The financing plan is a one-page table: source / type / amount / % / status (confirmed–pending–estimated) / conditions. It proves the budget closes and shows each funder they're not alone.

Illustrative Deep Dive structure (€1.35M) — *amounts illustrative; check RESEARCH note below on HAVC realism:* HAVC development 25k (confirmed) · HAVC production (tranches) · HRT pre-sale ~60k · rebate 25%×HR spend (estimated, late) · Italian minority co-pro (MiC/region/RAI) ~250k · Hungarian minority (NFI + HU 30% rebate) ~130k · Eurimages ≤20–25% (needs 50% confirmed per country) · sponsors ~40k · deferral/in-kind ≤15% cap. (!) **Reality check vs HAVC primary sources:** actual HAVC feature-doc production grants 2024–26 ran **€40–90k per film**

(results PDFs) — NOT €300k+. A €1.2–1.5M Croatian-majority doc closes only with the full international stack (partners + Eurimages + pre-sales + rebate + market money), or with a right-sized core budget. See "two budgets" strategy in the master doc.

The waterfall (order revenue is paid out): 1. CAM fee (~1%) > 2. sales agent commission 10–15% (to 20% on MGs) > 3. sales agent capped marketing expenses > 4. senior/bridge debt +8–12% > 5. gap +12–20% > 6. repayable soft money (Eurimages advance) > 7. equity principal + premium (110–120%, target returns 10–30%) > 8. deferrals > 9. net profits split. **Non-repayable soft money (HAVC grants, rebate) sits OUTSIDE the waterfall** — that's why €400k of grants beats €400k of equity: no repayment, no ownership.

Worked example — €500k gross sales, no equity/gap, Eurimages advance €270k (20% of budget): 500k - 5k CAM - 75k commission (15%) - 40k capped expenses - 76k Eurimages recoupment (20% of producer net receipts) - 20k deferrals = **€284k producer net > HR majority share (60%) ~ €170k**. Teaching points: €500k of "sales" = ~€170k for the majority producer (normal); with equity/gap in the stack, producer line ~ zero at this revenue level. **That is the argument for a soft-money-heavy plan.**

Eurimages mechanics (2025 regs): ≤€150k = non-refundable subsidy; >€150k = interest-free advance on receipts, repayable from first euro of each producer's net receipts at a rate equal to Eurimages' share of financing (after deducting the pre-sales that closed the budget); each co-producer repays proportionally, cap 100% of award. **Docs: max 25% of production cost, absolute cap €500,000.** Eligibility: ≥2 co-producers from different member states (HR, IT, HU all members); bilateral shares 20/80 (Eurimages' own rule); ≥50% of financing confirmed in each country at application; feature docs ≥70' for cinema.

CAMA (Collection Account Management Agreement): all buyers worldwide pay into one neutral escrow account (Fintage House or Freeway Entertainment; FilmChain newer); the CAM disburses per the agreed waterfall — self-executing, no "the money is with the Italian partner." Eurimages has a framework agreement with Freeway. Cost: setup + low single-digit % of collections. **Put "CAMA with Freeway/Fintage" in the co-production agreement from day one. Revenue flows through a CAMA or the deal doesn't close.**

4. International co-production mechanics

The core mechanic: one film, several producers, several national treasuries. Each co-producer raises its own national money (that's why they're invited), owns a proportional share (usually incl. home-territory revenues), and carries a **spend obligation** (e.g., HAVC minority scheme: ≥60% of Croatian support spent in Croatia; IT/HU equivalents). All fixed in the co-production agreement: shares, budget responsibility, spend geography, creative control (**protect final cut in writing**), over-cost liability, revenue split/territory carve-outs, credits, CAMA. The trade: co-production **multiplies soft-money surface** at the price of complexity + 25–40% of ownership — at €1.2–1.5M a Croatian doc essentially cannot close without it. **You don't "get" the partners' money — you get that much of the film MADE in their countries** (color in Rome, sound/score in Budapest). Plan post geography around the money.

Legal frame: 1992 European Convention (ETS 147): bilateral 20–80%, multilateral 10–70%, financial-only co-producers 10–25%, ≥15/19 points European-elements test. Revised Convention

(CETS 220, 2017, where all partners ratified): bilateral 10–90%, multilateral 5–80%, **dedicated documentary points grid** in appendices. If a partner state only ratified the 1992 text, the older convention governs. Verify HR/IT/HU ratification status at signing.

Sequencing lesson: Eurimages is *middle* money — HAVC + partner national money must be $\geq 50\%$ confirmed per country BEFORE filing. Typical order: HAVC development › partners + LOIs › HAVC production + partner funds › Eurimages › close with rebate estimate + pre-sale/sponsor.

4b. Croatian 25%+5% rebate — mechanics

Verified (filmingincroatia.hr; Invest Croatia): 25% cash rebate on qualifying Croatian spend (+5% in below-average-development regions — verify each municipality's index). Qualifying = Croatian goods/services + wages to Croatian tax residents, ex-VAT. **Docs minimum spend €60,000** (features 250k). Process: apply to HAVC ≥ 8 days before start of production with **proof of $\geq 70\%$ of financing** › provisional certificate › after Croatian work completes, **audited accounts** › final certificate › paid within ~90 days to a Croatian account. Effectively an entitlement (no competitive selection). Crew conditions kick in $>€500k$ HR spend (trainees) and $>€1M$ (3 HR HoDs + 50% HR crew).

Cash-flow truth: the rebate is money you must first spend. E.g., €700k HR qualifying spend › €175k back, arriving 6–12+ months after the spend, minus audit cost (€3–8k) — and it requires flawless Croatian bookkeeping from day one. Bridge options: treat as **last money in** (finances post/delivery, not the shoot); bank discounting against the provisional certificate. Sicily/Vegas travel generates NO Croatian rebate (an Italian partner's spend may feed Italy's incentive instead).

Stacking warning (GBER Art. 54, Reg. EU 651/2014): total public aid generally capped at **50% of budget — 60% for cross-border co-productions** (more for "difficult" works). Have HAVC confirm the cumulation math.

5. The five kinds of money

Money	Wants back	Real cost to you	Pays when	Use for
Grants/soft (HAVC, Eurimages, MEDIA)	Deliverables, reports, audits; Eurimages >150k a receipts corridor	Time + compliance + spend obligations; no ownership, no debt	Tranches, partly arrears	The foundation (50–70% of a EU doc)
Pre-sales (broadcaster/streamer early)	Exclusive territory/platform rights + delivery to spec	That territory's upside; delivery obligations	Small % signature, bulk on delivery	Credibility + bankable paper
Brand sponsorship	Association, content, credits	Soft editorial pressure — treat as a rights & editorial conversation; disclosure rules	Campaign milestones	Top-up; keep <10–15% of budget, outside final cut
Equity	Recoupment + premium (110–120%) + profits + reporting	Dilution + a permanently colder waterfall	Up front (its one advantage)	Last resort at this scale
Gap/debt	Principal + 12–20%, senior position	Interest + fees + legal; needs credible sales estimates	Up front, repaid first	Final 10–15% only if agent estimates support it

Why clean equity matters: every euro of equity/gap inserts a creditor above you and outlives the film. A grants+rebate+pre-sale doc pays its deferrals from the FIRST sale; the same doc with €200k equity at 120% pays €240k first — at doc revenue levels, that's usually the entire net. Soft-money-first is arithmetic, not idealism.

6. Tools financiers expect

- **Top sheet** (1-page category summary — read first for shape: post ~30%? contingency ~10%? sane fees?) + detailed budget (line items, qty × rate × time).
- Movie Magic Budgeting where bonds/studios are involved; for EU docs, funders accept clean spreadsheets in **their** templates (HAVC has its own forms — use exactly; Eurimages likewise). Doc-specific starting points: IDA sample budget PDF; Hot Docs budgeting guide PDF. AICP format = commercials, not docs.
- Full financier package: top sheet + detail (per-phase AND per-country columns for co-pros) + financing plan with status column + cumulative cash-flow + draft co-pro agreement + chain of title. During production: monthly **cost reports** (budget vs actual vs estimate-to-complete) from month one.
- IDA craft rules: don't hide real costs to look cheap; include publicity, stills, CC; budget employer payroll taxes on top of wages.

Verify-before-relying

1. HAVC current consolidated Pravilnik (7% cap verified NN 144/2014 čl. 8; amendments exist) + instalment schedule.
2. Rebate per-project cap, audit requirements, +5% region list (filmingincroatia@havc.hr).
3. Eurimages 2026 deadlines/instalments (coe.int/eurimages).
4. HR/IT/HU ratification of CETS 220 + the documentary points grid.
5. Hungarian 30% rebate + NFI minority terms (via HU partner).
6. GBER cumulation ceiling math (HAVC legal office).

Key sources

IDA 2025 budgeting intro + sample budget + "Don't Fudge on Your Budget" (documentary.org) · Hot Docs budgeting guide (assets.hotdocs.ca) · Fourwind Films budget guide (medium.com) · Producers Library pricing · Front Row / TH Agency E&O costs · EP "Beginner's Guide to the Film Financing Waterfall" (ep.com) · Cinelaunch waterfall · Stage 32 CAMA · Fintage House · Freeway Entertainment · Eurimages Regulations 2025 (rm.coe.int/coprodregulations-2025-en) + repayment conditions + application rules (coe.int) · ETS 147 + CETS 220 texts · filmingincroatia.hr · Invest Croatia rebate page · HAVC minority co-pro call 2026 · Pravilnik NN 144/2014 · Early Light Media cash-flow · Beverly Boy bridge loans · Media Services doc financing · Lab Thoughts brand-funded docs · IDA on corporate sponsors · Vitrina 2026 doc financing roadmap · CMS Productions / SetHero / StudioBinder budgeting tools.

VII

Research: Legal, Delivery & Sales

Chain of title, E&O; contracts, the delivery spec, sensitive content.

Full research report, 14 July 2026. Companion to PRODUCER-MASTER-STRATEGY.md.

General best-practice education, NOT legal advice — Deep Dive's defamation-risk storyline crossing HR/EU/UK/US law requires an entertainment/media lawyer engaged NOW.

Thesis: Buyers don't buy "the movie" — they buy a **bundle of proven, insured, technically compliant rights**. Everything below proves, insures, and packages those rights. Skip a layer and the sale dies at signature, at delivery, or after the money was spent.

1. Chain of title — the film's proof of ownership

The **unbroken sequence of signed agreements proving how every right flowed from its creator to your company** — checked at four gates: completion bond, E&O, treaty co-production certification, and the sale. A gap (missing assignment, unsigned release, undocumented transfer) "can delay or kill a distribution deal regardless of creative quality" (Thoolie; IndieWire; Rodriques Law).

The documents: (1) company formation docs; (2) underlying rights (if "based on" anything — for the 2023 case: facts are free, adaptation of specific journalism isn't); (3) **writer/director agreements assigning the film to the company** — critical when director = producer: without assignment the *person* owns the film, not the company; (4) producer/production services agreements; (5) **participant appearance releases** — every recognizable person; (6) life-story/depiction agreements for principals; (7) **crew deal memos with IP assignment** — footage a shooter shot is THEIR copyright until assigned; (8) location agreements/permits; (9) music: composer agreement + sync & master licenses; (10) **archival licenses** (competition footage likely belongs to federations/host broadcasters — big cost/risk item); (11) trademark/logo clearances or fair-use positions (sports docs are full of sponsor logos); (12) title report & copyright search (E&O insurers require it); (13) financing agreements & security discharges; (14) certificates of authorship / short-form assignments.

What breaks a chain: the unsigned release (subject leverage becomes total); the freelancer who never signed; **festival-only music licenses** when the streamer needs worldwide/all-media (re-clearing after lock = prices triple); verbal co-production promises; the corporate gap (contracts signed personally, entity never acquired the film).

Discipline: a live chain-of-title binder from day one — every agreement filed the day it's signed, one-line index. Producing it in 24 hours vs 3 panicked months = professional vs first-timer.

2. E&O insurance — the liability shield

Covers **defamation/libel, invasion of privacy, copyright/trademark infringement, idea theft, clearance failures** — and crucially pays **legal defense costs** (in a defamation suit, the process is the punishment; defense costs bankrupt indies even when they win). **No streamer/broadcaster takes a film without it** — plaintiffs sue everyone in the chain and the platform has the deepest pockets; E&O is a contractual condition of delivery.

Numbers: limits \$1M/\$3M indie standard (Netflix/HBO-tier often \$1M/\$5M+); deductible \$2.5–25k, buyers cap ≤\$10k; **term 3 years from delivery** (some want 5); premium **\$3–10k typical indie, \$20k+ for high-risk content**; carrier AM Best B+; buyer as additional insured, primary & non-contributory, waiver of subrogation. **Deep Dive: budget €10–20k** — a live doping/ethics controversy is exactly the content that pushes premiums up.

What the insurer requires (the application is an audit): clearance report/legal opinion (often attorney-signed); copyright & title searches; the entire chain of title; releases from every recognizable living person with edit rights; final music/archival licenses; for contentious content an **annotated transcript of the locked cut** — every factual assertion about the 2023 case footnoted to its evidence; and a **legal read of the near-final cut BEFORE picture lock** (recutting after lock re-triggers music conform, M&E, subtitles, QC). Start the E&O conversation at rough cut, not delivery.

Production insurance vs E&O: production package covers *physical* shoot risk (gear, media, liability, cast; for freediving add dive-specific/marine cover) and ends at wrap; E&O covers the *content* and lives 3+ years post-delivery. Two policies, often two insurers.

3. The key contracts — plain-language deal points

3.1 Director's agreement (even when directing your own film): the company must contract the director or chain of title has a hole exactly where buyers look first. Deal points: services through delivery incl. festivals/press; fixed fee (part-deferred normal at this scale — define the deferral trigger) + backend points; **rights assignment** (results & proceeds; in HR/continental Europe moral rights are inalienable — instead a broad consent to cuts/versions/edits, per FERA contract guidelines); credit; **creative controls** — default: company/financiers hold final cut, director gets consultation + defined cuts (DGA-style "two cuts and two previews"); buyers demand conform rights for ratings/law/platform — grant narrow, defined editing rights, never open-ended; suspension/termination/replacement (financiers require it even for director-producers — it's what makes the film financeable).

3.2 Participant releases & life-story rights — two different instruments:

- **Appearance release:** permission to film + use name/likeness/voice/interview in the film and promotion, worldwide, perpetuity, all media, with edit rights. Signed **on the day of filming, never "later"**. Everyone recognizable.
- **Life-story agreement** (principals): legally "there is no copyright in a life" — facts are free. What it actually buys: (1) **cooperation** (exclusive access, personal archive — the divers' own GoPro/dive-computer footage is THEIR copyright); (2) **exclusivity** (no competing doc access — Netflix asks "is this story locked?"); (3) **a covenant not to sue** (waiving defamation/privacy/publicity claims — what the E&O underwriter loves most); (4) optionally remake/scripted rights (cheap to option now, expensive after awards).
- **Control:** never grant cut approval (buyers may refuse a film a subject can veto; journalistically it taints the film). Defensible middle: right to view + notes; correction of factual errors; approval over

narrowly-defined private facts (medical details). Get releases from family/secondary figures too.

Blackout footage: specific consent to THAT footage (him, safety divers, medics) — privacy ≠ defamation; true medical facts can still violate privacy.

- **Paying subjects** is ethically contested (looks like buying testimony; raised against credibility in defamation fights) — modest materials/consulting fee or small backend, consistent and disclosed; lawyer's call.

3.3 Crew deal memos: rate/OT/kit/kill fee (10–25%); **assignment of all economic rights + consent to modifications** (US "work for hire" doesn't map to HR law — draft for Croatian law); credit at producer's discretion; confidentiality; **no-injunction clause** (crew can sue for money, not block release — buyers check); employment classification (ugovor o djelu / autorski ugovor / employment — local accounting advice).

3.4 Composer & music — the #1 doc clearance failure:

- **Commissioned score (recommended):** work-for-hire/full assignment — production owns composition AND master, all sync rights forever; or composer keeps copyright + grants broad license (must be worldwide/all-media/perpetuity incl. promos or the streamer deal snags). Composer keeps their **writer's share of PRO royalties** (costs you nothing — name on the cue sheet, collects from HDS-ZAMP/ASCAP when it airs). **Package deal** standard: one fee covers writing, musicians, studio, mixed masters **and stems** (needed for M&E).
- **Licensed music — every track needs TWO licenses:** sync (publisher) + master use (label), both matching your sale: worldwide, all media, term ≥ distribution term. Festival-only licenses are a trap. Never temp-track into loving an unclearable song.
- **Cue sheet:** timecoded list of every cue, usage, composer, publisher, PRO shares — mandatory delivery item and how the composer gets paid.

3.5 Editor agreement: weekly rate or flat fee + defined cuts + overage terms (doc edits ALWAYS overrun); full assignment of the cut; credit; no approval rights; **materials custody** (project files/timelines belong to production, handed over on request); post-lock services (delivery conforms, textless builds, QC fixes) priced in now.

3.6 Co-production agreement heads: each party's financial contribution (minimums matter for treaty status/Eurimages); copyright split tracking finance/spend; division of rights & territories (each keeps home territory is common); **the recoupment waterfall**; creative control (delegate producer; who approves cut, overruns, key hires); spend obligations per country; delivery obligations; credits (logo order!); festival strategy + who signs the sales agreement; default/buy-out mechanics; governing law/arbitration. One lawyer must read HAVC + Eurimages + broadcaster contracts side by side for contradictions.

3.7 Sales agent agreement — where good films die financially:

Term	Market range	Fight for
Commission	10–35% spectrum; ~ 20–25% doc norm ; >30% = red flag ; strong packages get 10–15%	15–20% with festival heat; tiered (lower % on a direct streamer sale they barely worked)
Advance/MG	Rare for docs; recoupable from your share	Don't trade a small advance for fat commission + long term

Term	Market range	Fight for
EXPENSE CAP	Typical actuals €20–30k; caps \$50–75k appear for features	Hard cap €20–40k for a doc + itemized approval above a threshold. No cap = the agent can spend your entire revenue
Term	5–15 yrs typical	7–10 max + performance reversion (no sales of €X by year 2 > rights revert). Never perpetuity without exploitation obligations
Territories	Worldwide ex-home common	Carve out Croatia/ex-YU if you have the HRT relationship
Deliverables	Full §4 list at your cost; "many producers spend 6–12 months delivering"	Negotiate the list down; exotic items "on request/at buyer's cost"
Reporting/audit	Quarterly/semi-annual; 24-month audit lookback	Both + copies of underlying distribution agreements

Red flags (walk away): no expense cap or "as incurred"; **cross-collateralization** (your revenue offset against their other titles, or expenses pooled across territories — "the producer's single most expensive recurring mistake"); 20+ year terms without reversion; refusing a CAMA; commission on money they didn't generate (your grants, festival prizes — exclude prize money from "revenue"); sub-licensing to affiliates without consent; upfront cash "marketing contributions"; commission on gross incl. withholding taxes.

3.8 Distributor/streamer license basics: license (defined rights/term/territory, rest stays yours) vs buyout (streamer "Originals" = effectively buyouts, bigger cheque, no backend). Terms 7–15 yrs standard licenses; streamer flat-fee often 2–5 yrs + renewals (shorter = better for you). Watch **holdbacks** (blocks on other windows — must match your festival/theatrical/HRT plans; vague window definitions = the most common distributor dispute). Money: flat license fee (streamer standard) or MG + revenue share (distributor: classic **10% on signature, 90% on delivery** — delivery is the payment trigger; a film that can't complete delivery sold itself for 10%). All conditioned on: accepted technical delivery + complete chain of title + live E&O naming them.

4. The delivery spec — "the thing that kills films"

The buyer must exploit the film in 190 countries, dub 30 languages, caption, cut promos, and defend it in court — without ever calling you again. The delivery schedule is the parts-list for that, and **the final 90% of your money is conditioned on its acceptance.**

A. Picture: graded master ProRes 4444/422HQ at native res (4K increasingly demanded); Netflix takes IMF; theatrical needs DCP. **Texted AND textless masters** — Deep Dive is full of lower-thirds, depth counters, subtitled Croatian: **plan the textless build during the online, not after.** Archival/mezzanine sometimes required.

B. Audio — where docs stumble: 5.1 printmaster + stereo (Lt/Rt), time-aligned WAVs; **the M&E (Music & Effects) track** — full mix minus all dialogue/narration so foreign dubs can be laid over.

Why it kills docs: vérité sound has dialogue and ambience on the same mic — you can't mute a channel; a proper doc M&E means rebuilding ambiances/effects under every dialogue scene ("filled M&E"). If the mixer doesn't build it DURING the mix, recreating later costs thousands and weeks. **Put "full filled 5.1 M&E + stems" in the sound-post contract NOW.** Stems (DX/MX/FX) for promos/re-versioning. Loudness compliance (e.g., Netflix -27 LKFS dialogue-gated).

C. Text/localization: timecoded dialogue/continuity/spotting list (for a bilingual CRO/EN film incl. translations — budget a pro service); CC/SDH files + the English subtitle file for Croatian dialogue.

D. Legal/admin: complete chain-of-title package; E&O certificate; music cue sheet + licenses; final credits + billing block + paid-ad restrictions + **HAVC/Eurimages logo placement obligations**; certified statements; lab access letters; tax forms; metadata package.

E. Marketing: 50–200 hi-res unit stills (no timecode/watermark) — **shoot stills DURING production; you cannot re-stage Etna or a world record**; layered key art (PSD); trailer.

F. QC — the gate: professional QC pass on everything (~\$500–3,000 per pass, ~\$1,500 typical). Common failures: loudness violations, sync drift, dead pixels/dropped frames in archival, interlacing from old comp footage, gamut errors, **M&E holes (audible dialogue bleed)**, subtitle timing, textless mismatching texted. Archival-heavy docs fail disproportionately. Failed QC = re-master + paid second pass + **4–8 weeks of lost release window; hold \$3–5k contingency.**

Cost & time reality: deliverables take 5–6 weeks in post; QC ~ 4–5× runtime per version; producers routinely spend **6–12 months** completing delivery; realistic all-in delivery budget at this level **€25–60k+.** **The first-timer death spiral:** sign a 90%-on-delivery deal > discover M&E was never built > sound post wants €12k and 6 weeks > miss delivery date > window slips > deal cools. Every element preventable in the original post contracts. **Prevention:** (1) put a real streamer delivery schedule in front of the post supervisor BEFORE contracting the online/mix; (2) make M&E, textless, stems, spotting list contractual deliverables of the sound house/online facility; (3) hold 5% of post budget as delivery contingency; (4) negotiate the buyer's list down before signature ("if available"/"at buyer's cost" items are wins).

5. Pitch & marketing materials taxonomy

Logline (1 sentence, 25–40 words) > short synopsis (100–150 w, the STORY not the topic) > long synopsis (1 p, incl. resolution) > director's statement (0.5–1 p: why you, why now, your access, ethics of the 2023 storyline) > treatment (5–20 pp: structure, characters, scenes, visual language, archival plan) > **pitch deck/lookbook (12–15 slides:** title+logline · story · the four · the world · the 2023 case & why it matters · visual approach/mood frames · access & archival · team · budget + finance plan with status · comparables (*The Deepest Breath*, *Icarus* — the doping-doc comp) · distribution/festival strategy · status & timeline · contact) > sizzle (1–3 min proof-of-concept for an UNFINISHED film — the thing that raises money) vs teaser (<=1 min public atmospheric) vs trailer (90–150s, for the FINISHED film) > one-pager/sales sheet (key art, logline, specs, laurels, contact) > EPK (5–15 pp: verified facts, synopses, statements, bios, 3–10 clean stills, poster, trailer links, press, contacts — many festivals require it) > unit stills (100–200, during production) > poster/key art (layered PSD).

By stage: financing (now > IDFA Forum): logline, synopsis, statement, treatment, deck, sizzle. Festival premiere: EPK, stills, teaser, poster, press strategy. Sales: one-pager, trailer, screener, deck+laurels. Delivery: trailer, stills, layered art, EPK become contractual deliverables. **Build once,**

use three times.

6. Sensitive real-life / defamation-risk content (the 2023 chapter)

1. **Truth, rigorously documented** — truth is the defense, but only *provable* truth. Keep an **annotation file**: every assertion in the cut > footnoted to a document, on-record interview, or official finding. Distinguish adjudicated fact ("was sanctioned under the Code of Ethics") from allegation ("competitors claim") — make the film's language match.
2. **Avoid actual malice/recklessness** — public figures (world-record athletes qualify) must prove knowing falsity or reckless disregard (US); protection is process: contemporaneous notes, fact-checking, considering contrary evidence AND keeping the record that you considered it. Reckless = ignoring an obvious contrary source, single motivated accuser, editing an answer to reverse meaning.
3. **Right of reply** — before lock, send the accused party/parties a written summary of the specific allegations and invite response; include the response (or "declined to comment") in the film; **archive the correspondence** — Exhibit A of good faith. Applies to the federation as much as any individual. Europe adds wrinkles: criminal defamation survives in parts of the Balkans; UK libel is claimant-friendly — the lawyer must be cross-border aware.
4. **Legal read of the fine cut before lock** — flags unprovable assertions, private facts (medical/furosemide detail = defamation AND privacy issue), juxtapositions that imply guilt (the edit can defame even when every line is true), music/archival gaps.
5. **Participant consent as risk-transfer** — covenants not to sue shrink the plaintiff pool to non-participants, where right-of-reply + annotation take over.
6. **Privacy ≠ defamation** — true statements can violate privacy (private medical facts, secret recordings, medical-emergency footage). Blackout: specific consent.
7. **E&O ties it together** — insurer demands 1–6 as underwriting conditions; done early they LOWER the premium; done late they force post-lock recuts, the most expensive edits in film.

Deep Dive priority actions (July 2026)

1. Engage the media lawyer this month (HR + international reach): chain-of-title audit, release templates, right-of-reply protocol.
2. Audit Krk + Sicily releases — every person, shooter, location; fix gaps while relationships are warm.
3. Lock the four with life-story-style agreements (cooperation + materials + covenant not to sue; no cut approval — chapter-limited viewing right per the working-paper promise).
4. Scope archival early — who owns 2023 competition/broadcast footage; quotes for worldwide/all-media/10+ yrs into the finance plan.
5. Contract sound post with delivery in mind: filled 5.1 M&E, stems, loudness, textless — in the deal memo.
6. **Budget the invisible €40–80k**: E&O 10–20k, delivery/QC 25–60k, legal 10–25k, CAMA setup — before the next financier conversation.
7. Start E&O application at rough cut (annotation + legal read scheduled pre-lock).

8. IDFA Forum: deck 12–15 slides, sizzle 1–3 min, treatment, statement — and be ready for "who owns the film and is the story locked?" (a chain-of-title and life-rights question in a pitch-meeting costume).

Key sources

Chain of title: Thoolie guide · IndieWire · Seed&Spark · Rodriques Law · Film Finance Attorney · Tools for Film checklist. E&O: IDA "Errors & Omissions" guide (documentary.org) · Kelly Insurance FAQ · Wrapbook · Front Row 101 · thagency cost · Film Emporium · Romano Law. Contracts: Wrapbook director agreements · DGA creative rights · FERA directors' contract guidelines (filmzaken.com PDF) · Marc Jacobson · Thoolie 2026 director guide · IDA life-story rights · Mark Litwak life rights · Hollywood Reporter · Romano Law · StudioBinder/Wrapbook/SetHero/Saturation deal memos · WMM sample memo · Lunacy + MusicContracts composer · Levantine music rights · NYSBA cue sheets. Co-pro: CoE IRIS Plus · European Audiovisual Observatory · FilmDaily · Entertainment Partners · Stage 32. Sales: Vitrina deal terms · Thoolie distribution guide · Distribution Advocates cheat sheet · Guerrilla Rep · Stage 32 CAM · Zannoni · FilmChain · Eurimages CAM rules · Ty Leisher. Delivery: Netflix Partner Help (branded specs, M&E incl. nonfiction) · Guerrilla Rep deliverables · Film Independent "Deliverables Demystified" · Slingshot · Thoolie checklist · Vitrina cost · +Reel hidden costs · MoltenCloud · Production Expert · Film Collaborative. Pitch: DocFilmAcademy deck + sizzle · Desktop Documentaries · Viktori · Filmsourcing/FilmDaft/StudioBinder EPK. Defamation: PBS Media Law 101 · The Clearance Lab (×2) · Safe + Secure · Cornell LII · DMLP · Aaron Hall.

VIII

Releases: Draft Terms

Participant and life-story terms for the lawyer, incl. the 2023 chapter.

(!) NOT FOR SIGNING. This is the brief + draft terms for a Croatian media lawyer, who converts it into a binding HR/EN bilingual agreement. Target: signed at Lastovo (20 Jul–9 Aug).

*Sign with: Tomislav Kovačić as producer, **with assignment right to the production d.o.o. upon its registration** (company in founding).*

Who signs what

- **The Four** (Petar Klovar, Vitomir Maričić, Sanda Delija, Zsófia Törőcsik): full agreement below.
- **Supporting participants** (family, Borna if featured, coaches, camp students, safety team): the simplified one-pager (Annex C).
- **Crew** (Toni, Kristijan, others): separate work-for-hire deal memos — all footage/IP to producer; re-paper Krk + Sicily work onto the d.o.o. once founded.

Draft terms — the Four

1. **Grant of rights.** Appearance, interview, likeness, voice, name, and biographical/life-story elements; plus personal archive materials the participant chooses to provide (family photos/video) under a per-item schedule (Annex B). For: the feature documentary, the companion series (3 eps), and their promotion (trailers, stills, poster, socials, EPK).
2. **Scope.** All media now known or later devised, worldwide, for the full term of protection — required for any streamer/broadcaster sale. (Lawyer: structure as contractual licence of personality rights + archive licence, not mere GDPR consent, to limit revocability; HR pravo osobnosti + GDPR interplay is the core drafting job.)
3. **Editorial control.** Producer/director holds final cut — **except the "2023 Chapter"** (defined: all scenes substantially depicting the Vertical Blue 2023 events, the search, the CMAS proceedings and their direct aftermath). For that chapter only, each of the Four has: (a) the right to view the chapter cut before any third party outside the production sees it; (b) an approval right over that chapter's inclusion of their own contributions. This mirrors the promises in the 2023 Working Paper — and is deliberately **chapter-limited** so E&O and streamer delivery remain possible.
4. **The blackout clause (Petar).** Footage of the Sicily blackout and recovery may be used only in context that includes/reflects his own account (the post-event interview). No isolated use in marketing without his written OK. (He's already given the interview — this papers the trust.)
5. **Health & science material.** Physiological/medical imagery and data (Rijeka lab block: ultrasound, EEG, etc.) = GDPR special-category data › separate explicit consent annex (Annex D), per session, with the University's own ethics paperwork alongside.

6. **Compensation.** [TOMO — decide before Lastovo. Options: (a) symbolic fee now + defined % net-profit participation shared by the Four; (b) deferred fee payable from first commercial revenue; (c) fee only. Bible principle "they're partners, not subjects" > (a) recommended.]
7. **No obligation** to produce, complete, or release the film; no obligation to use any particular material.
8. **Truth & third-party rights.** Participant warrants their statements are true to their knowledge and that provided archive is theirs to give (or flags whose it is).
9. **Safety.** Filming never directs or overrides diving activity; the participant's sporting decisions are their own; producer's liability limited to the filming activity itself. (Lawyer: coordinate with production insurance wording.)
10. **Exclusivity (soft).** During production, participant won't grant a competing feature-documentary crew substantially similar access (news/social/short-form excluded — their careers continue normally).
11. **Withdrawal.** Participant may stop future filming at any time; already-recorded material remains licensed (subject to clauses 3–5).
12. **Credit.** [e.g., "with Petar Klovar, Vitomir Maričić, Sanda Delija, Zsófia Törőcsik" main titles; consult them on form.]
13. **Law & forum.** Croatian law; court [Rijeka]. Binding language HR; EN courtesy translation for Zsófia (or bilingual both-binding — lawyer's call).

Annexes

- **A** — Definition of "2023 Chapter" (scene-type list, so approval scope is objective).
- **B** — Archive materials schedule (item, source, owner, permitted use).
- **C** — Supporting-participant one-pager: appearance + likeness, all media, worldwide, perpetual, no approval rights, GDPR notice, signature. Keep it to one page — camp students and family sign this between dives.
- **D** — Special-category (health) data consent, per lab session.

Lawyer brief (send with this file)

Find: HR media/entertainment lawyer with doc/streamer delivery experience. Ask them to: (1) convert to bilingual agreement + annexes; (2) solve the GDPR-revocability vs contract-licence structure; (3) sanity-check clause 3 against E&O insurability; (4) advise on the 2023 archive (secretly-filmed search video — privacy/copyright/defamation exposure and the truth defence given negative WADA tests + ITA no-violation + Škerbić et al. 2025); (5) fixed quote. Budget line exists in MASTER-PLAN §4.

IX

IDFA Forum Entry Draft

The 25 July submission: logline, synopsis, finance plan, checklist.

*Deadline: **25 July 2026, 23:59 CEST** · entry fee €30 · professionals.idfa.nl › Markets ›*

Enter your project

Forum: 15–18 Nov 2026, Amsterdam. Category: project in production seeking co-financing/co-production.

[TOMO] marks = fill or approve before submitting. Keep answers in this file; we paste into the portal together.

Project title: DEEP DIVE **Format:** Feature documentary, 90–100 min (companion 3×45' series in development) **Countries:** Croatia (majority) — seeking IT / HU / DE / FR minority partners **Languages:** Croatian, English, Hungarian, Italian **Stage:** In production — 2 of 7 shoot blocks completed · delivery Q4 2027 **Total budget:** €1,200,000 [TOMO: confirm envelope — plan allows up to 1.5M] **Financing in place:** €35,000 (producer's own investment, cash + in-kind to date) [TOMO: confirm figure] **Requested at Forum:** minority co-producers, broadcaster pre-sales (ARTE / ZDF / YLE / BBC Storyville), sales agent, funds

Logline (pick one)

1. Four best friends hold three of freediving's four absolute world records — and one documented injustice that tried to brand two of them cheats. A year in the deep with the people who go where humans shouldn't survive, and the hands that pull them back.
2. One person holds another in the world: the world's deepest man, his mentor who can stop breathing for half an hour, and the two women whose world record passed between best friends — a story of trust filmed at the edge of blackout.

[TOMO: instinct?]

Synopsis (~250 words — draft)

Petar Klovar dives deeper without fins than any human in history. His mentor Vitomir Maričić holds the Guinness record for the longest breath ever held — twenty-nine minutes — and studies his own physiology at the University of Rijeka's hyperbaric research centre. Sanda Delija was the first Croatian woman past a hundred metres; her free-immersion world record was taken, one metre at a time, by her best friend Zsófia Törőcsik — who three years ago had never freedived at all. Two couples, one mentor, one tight universe on the Croatian coast.

In 2023, at the sport's most famous competition, an airport luggage search — secretly filmed and posted online — branded Petar and Vito cheats. Their tests came back negative from a

WADA-accredited lab; the international federation punished them anyway, through a three-page code of ethics. A peer-reviewed academic paper has since called the case procedurally and ethically wrong. In September 2026, the same world that tried to disgrace Vito will induct him into the International Sports Hall of Fame in Las Vegas — in the same class as Garry Kasparov.

DEEP DIVE follows all four across one year — from home water on Krk, through a world-record attempt under an erupting Etna that ended in a blackout and an open-eyed interview minutes later, to the deepest training camps of the Adriatic and the applause in Vegas. Above the surface the film is alive and moving; below it, sacred and still. It is not a film about depth. It is a film about who waits for you at the surface.

Director's statement (skeleton — [TOMO: voice pass])

- Why me: inside access nobody else has — a year of trust, the four as co-authors of their own hardest chapter (the 2023 working-paper method).
- The grammar: dynamic above the surface, sacred below. The cut between the two worlds is the film.
- The bets: the score built from their own physiology; one record dive in real time, unbroken; four voices braided into one descent monologue.
- The ethics: negative tests, an ethics-code punishment, a peer-reviewed rebuttal — rigour, never spectacle; their truth, on their terms, with veto over that chapter alone.

Production status (honest, specific)

- **Shot:** Krk (Apr–Jun 2026 — the four, families, home water, national championship) · Sicily (1–6 Jul 2026 — Petar's monofin world-record attempt ending in blackout + immediate interview; Mount Etna erupted during the shoot window — the film's opening image is in the can).
- **Ahead:** Lastovo depth camps 20 Jul–9 Aug (the sport laid bare; the deep 2023 conversations) · USA, 3 weeks around 26 Sept (ISHOF induction, Las Vegas; Vegas>San Francisco road trip; possible coda) · AIDA World Championships, Limassol 27 Sept–10 Oct (subject to athletes' schedule) · University of Rijeka hyperbaric lab (the science block) · coda night dive (bioluminescence).
- **Editing:** assembly from Nov 2026, rough cut spring 2027, lock summer 2027.

Finance plan (draft — [TOMO: adjust before submitting])

Source	Status	Amount
Producer's own investment (cash + in-kind)	secured	€35,000
Brand partners (dive industry + Croatian)	in negotiation	€75,000
HAVC production support	applying 10 Sept 2026	€50,000

Source	Status	Amount
HRT (Croatian broadcaster) pre-sale /co-production	in discussion	€40,000
Italian minority co-producer + funds	seeking (Forum)	€150,000
Hungarian minority co-producer + NFI	seeking (Forum)	€100,000
Eurimages (with co-producers attached)	2027 application	€280,000
Filming in Croatia rebate (25%+5% on HR spend incl. post)	eligible	€70,000
Broadcaster pre-sales / sales agent MG	seeking (Forum)	€400,000
Total		€1,200,000

Company & team

- **Production:** [TOMO: d.o.o. name — founding in progress, single owner Tomislav Kovačić]
- **Director/Producer:** Tomislav Kovačić — Croatian director & cinematographer; [TOMO: 2–3 line bio — commercial/branded work, production background, why this story found you]
- **Cinematography:** Tomislav Kovačić + 2-camera field unit (operators double as post team) [TOMO: names/credits]
- **Croatian co-producer:** in negotiation (shortlist prepared) — attach before Forum if possible
- Athletes' PR handled separately (Select PR) — film retains full editorial independence.

Materials checklist for the entry

- [] Sizzle/promo 3–5 min (Krk + Sicily + Etna) — private Vimeo link, password
- [] 2–3 stills per shoot block (the breath-up, the watchers, Etna over the sea)
- [] This document's fields pasted into portal
- [] €30 fee (card)
- [] Deadline guard: submit by **24 July** — never on deadline day.